

US President Says Houthis Agree Not to Attack US



Donald Trump

Washington: President Donald Trump said Sunday that Yemen's Houthis have agreed not to attack the United States, even as the Iran-allied group steps up its campaign against US ally Saudi Arabia, Fox News reported.

Fox News reporter Trey Yingst, who frequently speaks with Trump, cited the president as saying Washington is "in constant communication with the Houthis and that they've agreed not to fight the US." Trump has previously claimed the Houthis are holding back from attacking US forces in the region.

"The Houthis called us and they don't want to fight with us," Trump said during a visit to Ireland on Sept. 12. "They don't want us to go after them."

His latest comments to Fox News came as Saudi Arabia faces growing pressure, including a missile attack targeting the capital Riyadh on Saturday.

The Houthis have also launched a rapid offensive inside Yemen, seizing swathes of territory from the internationally recognised government, which is backed by Saudi Arabia.

Fox News reported that Trump is in "deciding mode" on Iran, where US and Israeli forces launched a major aerial bombing campaign on Feb. 28 before settling into a nearly seven-month standoff.

Yingst said Trump told him that "big things will be happening in the not so distant future" and that "Iranians better behave," as he weighs whether to "blow up their nation." **AFP**

Iran Warns of Wider Retaliation If US, Allies Launch New Attack

US warns of possible Middle East escalation, urges Americans to remain vigilant

Dubai: Iran warned on Sunday against any major new attack by the United States and its allies, saying it had information that such a move was being prepared, adding to tensions in a region already on edge after drone and missile strikes on Saudi Arabia.

Iran's military central command said on state media that any new attack would trigger sustained retaliation against US bases and interests, and that Washington's regional allies would be considered parties to the conflict. It gave no details on the information it said pointed to an imminent US attack.

The US State Department issued a security alert on Saturday warning of the potential for unforeseen escalation in the Middle East and urging Americans to exercise greater vigilance, citing possible flight cancellations and airspace closures.

Nearly seven months into the US-Iran war, neither side appears ready to make the major concessions needed to end the fighting. With global energy markets already stretched, the conflict continues to spill across the region.

On Saturday, Yemen's Iran-backed Houthis, who have made major gains



People take part in a rally in Washington on Saturday in support of women's rights and equality in Iran

DIPLOMATIC IMPASSE



Nearly seven months into the US-Iran war, neither side appears ready to make major concessions needed to end the fighting

along Yemen's Red Sea coast since the country's civil war reignited this month, said they had attacked the Saudi capital Riyadh and a major oil facility in the Red Sea port of Yanbu.

Videos showed a huge plume of black smoke rising near Riyadh's

main international airport after explosions were heard overnight. Saudi Arabia did not comment on the incident or the Houthi claims, but a Saudi-led coalition fighting the group said it had foiled other attacks on the kingdom. **Reuters**

Turkey Signals Military Support for Saudi Arabia Against Houthis

Ankara: Turkey's Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan signalled technical military support for Saudi Arabia against attacks by Iran-backed Houthi militants in Yemen, in line with last month's Mecca Defence Alliance.

"There may be military needs, particularly in certain technical areas, and we would have no problem meeting them," Fidan said in an NTV interview late Saturday when asked whether Houthi attacks on Saudi Arabia would activate the trilateral defence agree-

ment. Pakistan, the third member of the alliance, has also pledged military support to the kingdom.

Saudi Arabia is being drawn deeper into the regional fallout from the war with Iran, facing intensifying attacks as Iran-backed Houthis in Yemen target western cities and energy infrastructure. On Saturday, Riyadh said it intercepted a ballistic missile headed for the capital and thwarted separate Houthi attacks on civilian sites.

The attacks are testing the new de-

fence pact linking Saudi Arabia with Turkey and Pakistan, both US partners, as the two countries signal support for Riyadh without committing to a wider military intervention.

"We see very serious attacks against Saudi Arabia's territorial integrity and sovereignty," Fidan said. Three days earlier, his ministry condemned the Houthis over a drone attack on Mecca, Islam's holiest city. "Under our alliance, we stand by our word," Fidan said. **BB**

German Chancellor Merz's Party Faces Fresh Setback in State Elections

Berlin: Exit polls showed Chancellor Friedrich Merz's party suffering heavy losses in two German state elections on Sunday, increasing pressure on a leader who has struggled to deliver on promises to revive Europe's biggest economy and curb the rise of the far-right AfD party.

Merz's centre-right Christian Democratic Union was projected to win 5.5% in Mecklenburg-Western Pomerania, a largely rural state in Germany's former communist east. That would be its worst result there since World War II.

In Berlin, the CDU was projected to finish second with 20%, behind the Left party at 24.5%, according to an exit poll by public broadcaster ARD.

The anti-migration, Russia-friendly Alternative for Germany party made significant gains in both elections. The votes came two weeks after the AfD fell just short of a majority in the small eastern state of Saxony-Anhalt, where it now has its strongest chance yet of forming Germany's first far-right regional government since World War II.

Merz's authority was severely weakened by his party's stinging defeat to the AfD in the Sept. 6 election, a result that shocked many Germans who had believed their country had developed an immunity to nationalism and assertions of racial superiority after confronting the horrors of its Nazi past through education and laws against persecution. **AP**

Denmark: Greenland Sovereignty Intact under US Agreement

Copenhagen: Denmark said on Saturday its sovereignty over Greenland would not be compromised by a deal taking shape with the Trump administration that would allow a significant expansion of the US military presence on the Arctic island.

The US, Denmark and Greenland said on Friday they had reached an agreement to expand the US military footprint in the self-governing Danish territory while preventing US adversaries from establishing bases there.

Key details, including the scale of the planned buildup and whether Washington would gain any formal authority over foreign policy or natural resources, have not been made public. **Reuters**

Trump Wants Proposed Memorial Arch in Washington to Serve Military Purpose

Says planned 250-foot memorial arch to house drones, snipers and ammunition



File photo of Memorial Bridge, the proposed site for US President Donald Trump's 'Triumphal Arch' "military complex" and argued that it is necessary for national security purposes.

The Republican president said in a social media post that he had agreed, at the "strong request" of the military, to convert the planned 250-foot-tall (76-metre) memorial arch "into a top-grade

Military Complex/Triumphal Arch, to house, store, and have the rapid ability to use large numbers of drones, plus Snipers, on both the roof and plaza areas, and additionally have and hold large quantities of sniper ammunition in storage."

The arch, proposed for a circle adjacent to the Memorial Bridge, is one of several projects the Republican president is pursuing to leave a lasting imprint on Washington. Among the others are the White House ballroom, the renaming and renovation of the Kennedy Center, refurbishment of the Lincoln Memorial Reflecting Pool and rebuilding a golf course in East Potomac Park that could significantly reduce public access to running and biking paths. **AP**

Ed Sheeran Calls Conditions in Gaza 'Unjustifiable' Post Backlash

Pop star Ed Sheeran said Saturday the situation in Gaza is "unjustifiable," following a wave of criticism that he had failed to back his opening act who was booed from the tour after making pro-Palestinian comments.

The singer, who had previously maintained an apolitical stance, broke his silence on the Israeli-Palestinian conflict in his first show since the controversy involving US rapper Macklemore.

"What is happening in Gaza is catastrophic and unjustifiable and disproportionate," Sheeran said in Philadelphia.

"Our hearts have been broken by the scale of devastation and loss

of civilians' lives, children's lives, and the systemic injustice we're seeing unfold in the West Bank cannot be overlooked."

Macklemore had declared "Free Palestine" at a New Jersey concert this month, drawing backlash from owners of US stadiums hosting future dates of Sheeran's Lo-p Tour.

The British artist, 35, has denied being behind the decision to remove the rapper, instead blaming the tour promoter.

Four supporting acts subsequently walked out on the "Shape of You" singer, issuing public statements citing their support for Palestinians. **AFP**

Two Ballistic Missiles in 3 Hrs N Korea Fires Off East Coast

Seoul: North Korea launched two missiles off its eastern coast on Sunday, its second set of tests in roughly a week and days after Pyongyang accused the US of driving tensions on the Korean Peninsula through a series of military drills.

Just three hours after laun-

ching a short-range ballistic missile (SRBM) toward the East Sea on Sunday afternoon, North Korea fired another short-range ballistic missile, according to South Korea's defence ministry.

If the subsequent launch is confirmed to be a ballistic mis-

sile, it will mark two consecutive ballistic missile tests by North Korea within a three-hour window.

South Korea's Joint Chiefs of Staff said it detected the first test firing from the Wonsan area around 11:30 AM, identifying it as a ballistic missile. **Reuters**



Scott Bessent and He Lifeng

DISCUSSION ON TRADE, ENERGY AND AI

US, China Trade Talks Set Stage for Trump-Xi Meet

US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent and China's Vice Premier He Lifeng will lead talks on trade and other pressure points Sunday in New York ahead of next week's summit between the leaders of the world's two biggest economies.

The negotiators will lay the groundwork for a high-profile meeting between President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping on Sept. 24 in Washington. Bessent and He last met face-to-face near Seoul four months ago, just days before Trump visited Beijing in May.

Energy disruptions from the Iran war, the artificial intelligence boom, and trade and investment are likely to top the agenda as both sides work to maintain stability in a tariff truce that expires in November.

Adding urgency for US officials to extend the deal are Nov. 3 midterm elections where inflation is a persistent voter concern.

The US is "at a stage with China where efforts to try and transform this relationship and strengthen it are no longer top of list," said Wendy Cutler, senior vice president at the Asia Society Policy Institute.

The objective is more about "trying to keep things stable, keep things from escalating and try to, in practical terms, keep the trade truce that was reached in Busan in place," she said.

US Trade Representative Jamie-ion Greer will also attend talks, according to a statement from his office. "The Trump Administration will continue to pursue balanced trade with China by monitoring the implementation of recent com-

mitments, optimizing trade in non-sensitive goods, and improving market access for American farmers, manufacturers, and workers," he said in the statement late Friday.

China's Commerce Ministry on Saturday confirmed the talks would take place.

An announcement of new US tariffs over allegations of trading partners' excess manufacturing capacity has been delayed until after the meeting, according to people familiar with the matter.

"Both sides want to avoid another flare-up and relative stability in the relationship is likely to continue," Nicole Gorton-Carattelli, Adam Farrar and Maeva Cosuin of Bloomberg Economics wrote in a research note this week. "But as the US rebuilds its tariff wall, the risk of renewed escalation remains."

The US and China have been working to reduce levies on American energy and agricultural products, part of a broader initiative to ease barriers on \$30 billion worth of products from each side under the Board of Trade mechanism launched earlier this year. **Bloomberg**

Moscow Refinery Damaged in Record Ukraine Drone Attack



Flames & smoke rise from Moco's oil refinery after a large-scale Ukrainian drone attack on Sunday

Strike comes as Russia holds final day of parliamentary voting

Moscow: The Moscow Oil Refinery was hit during drone attacks that were part of Ukraine's largest overnight barrage this year, as Russia entered the final day of voting in parliamentary elections.

Russia's Defense Ministry said it shot down 1,110 Ukrainian drones across 19 regions and Crimea, the largest overnight total reported this year and well above the previous high of 822 in August.

It also said air defences destroyed eight Ukrainian Flamingo missiles and 1,951 drones over the past day, Interfax reported.

Several drones struck the Moscow refinery, damaging a facility at the site, Moscow Mayor Sergei Sobyanin said on Telegram. No one was hurt and emergency services were working at the scene, he said.

Gazprom Neft PJSC owns the refinery; about 25 kilometers from the Kremlin. It can process about 245,000 barrels of crude a day and is

a key fuel supplier to the capital region.

Ukraine's General Staff said the refinery's AVT-6 primary crude oil distillation unit, an integrated crude oil processing unit and an isomerization unit were hit, with large fires reported at the site. Gazprom Neft didn't immediately respond to a request for comment. Two people were killed and 20 injured in drone strikes in the Moscow region, Governor Andrey Vorobyev said on Telegram.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said a Pelican ballistic missile was also used in the attacks, marking the first publicly confirmed combat use of the system. **BB**

Italy to Ban Burqas, Limit Foreign Students: Meloni

Rome: Italy will ban burqas and niqabs in schools and limit the number of foreign students per class, far-right Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni said Sunday.

Italy is a frontline country for migration, and integration is a major campaign issue ahead of a general election next year.

"A measure will soon be presented to a cabinet meeting to legally establish a maximum number of foreign students per class," Meloni told a gathering of the youth wing of her Brothers of Italy (Fdi) party.

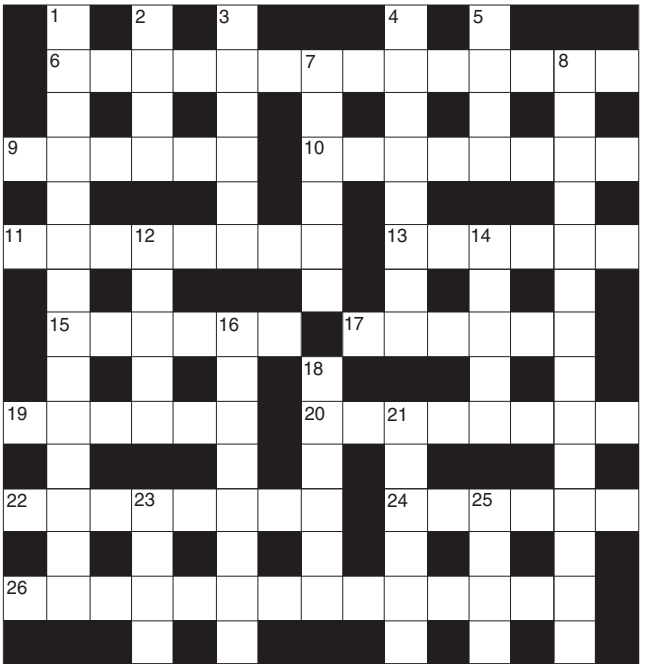
"It also requires parents of foreign students facing serious difficulties integrating into the school system to learn Italian, and bans burqas and niqabs in schools," she said.

The National Future (FN) party called for a crackdown on the use of burqas in schools in July. The FN, which is not part of the governing coalition, is further to the right than Meloni's party. **AFP**



Crossword

9709



ACROSS

6 New soy importers accept no written pledge to pay (10,4)

9 Fake group of skiers at Zermatt (6)

10 Inconvenient and curiously drawn out (8)

11 Lose account in simple mistake (8)

13 Note: two Queens separated by a victory (6)

15 Protein in abundance east and north (6)

17 Disco music chief probes bum note (6)

19 Someone who 13s in cellar? (6)

20 Eternal name for priest in Somerset? (8)

22 Submarine flounders each time it emerges (8)

24 Score +10, craving drink (not small) (6)

26 French sea song by Josephine about navy financier (8,6)

DOWN

1 Scraping 17 represented fair opportunity (8,6)

2 9 meat or bean (4)

3 Place where one gets stuck into Roman dish? (6)

4 After treatment, Eric quit 'The Review' (8)

5 Recognise weekend present (4)

7 U.S. race washed out; cup rests on it (6)

8 Peter and Ruth not in crash in manoeuvre (5-5,4)

12 Courage to prepare turkey (5)

14 Some chap hides ladybird food (5)

16 22 transport providing new routes to most of the centre of Paris (8)

18 On German isle in the 5 (2,4)

21 Snare savage panther? Hard going (6)

23 Cut most of 17 roughly (4)

25 It's very dark in outlying parts of Kentucky (4)

SOLUTION TO No. 9708:

ACROSS: 1 Law Lord. 5 Prissy. 9 Idiocy. 10 Redraft. 11 Lot. 12 Palpitation. 13 Wheel. 14 Demagogue. 16 Rat poison. 17 Whack. 19 Appealingly. 22 Ann. 23 Tailors. 24 Ukraine. 26 Agreed. 27 Diptych.

DOWN: 1 Laid low. 2 Whistle-stopping. 3 Out. 4 Ducal. 5 Persimmon. 6 India. 7 Seating capacity. 8 Stance. 12 Pollo. 14 Dismissed. 15 Gawky. 16 Roasts. 18 Kenneth. 20 Abode. 21 Glued. 25 Rap.

HIDATO
FIND THE PATH - SOLVE THE PUZZLE

Complete the grid so that numbers 1-63 connect horizontally, vertically or diagonally.

63
1 4
14 5 61 56
12 16 6 24 55
10 23
39 8 22
43 28 52
41 46 51
33

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Difficulty: ★★☆☆

Hidato Sol.

Yesterday's puzzle solution.

36 31 30 29 16 17 23 22
37 35 32 28 15 24 18 21
38 33 34 27 25 14 19 20
39 42 43 45 26 13 69 70
40 41 46 44 12 68 71 72
49 48 47 56 57 11 10 1
51 50 65 56 57 9 2 3
52 64 55 62 58 8 7 4
53 54 63 61 60 59 6 5

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7 LITTLE WORDS

Find the 7 words to match the 7 clues. The numbers in parentheses represent the number of letters in each solution. Each letter combination can be used only once, but all letter combinations will be necessary to complete the puzzle.

CLUES

1 how a hungry person eats (10)
2 builds to a peak in volume (11)
3 backless couches (6)
4 like modern calendars (9)
5 let loose (7)
6 "capture the flag" game (8)
7 in need of a certain roller (5)

SOLUTIONS

1 how a hungry person eats (10)
2 builds to a peak in volume (11)
3 backless couches (6)
4 like modern calendars (9)
5 let loose (7)
6 "capture the flag" game (8)
7 in need of a certain roller (5)

RAVE IAN END SLY DIV
SC GED NTY UN GO
CA ATE GRE OES CRE
ANS LI NOU STR GOR

Yesterday's Answers: 1. BLOT 2. NUTKIN 3. RICE 4. COURTNEY'S 5. UNUSUAL 6. HOMOPHIAS 7. APPLE



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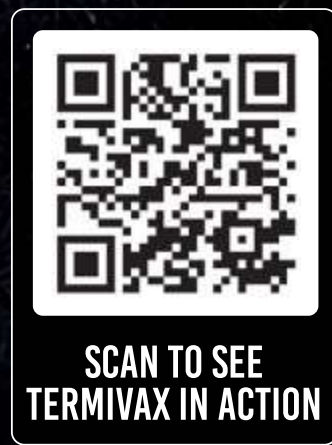


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TO KNOW MORE*, VISIT: WWW.GREENPLY.COM *Patent Applied for

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'SMALL' FINANCE BANK. REALLY?





'SMALL' FINANCE BANK. REALLY?



MONTHS BEFORE INKING AN AGREEMENT WITH PAKISTAN MILITARY

Don Jr-Linked Co Signs up to Make Anti-Drone Systems in India

INDIAN 'GUARDIAN 1' DEAL
"Powerus grants Paras an exclusive licence to use the licensed IP within India for... manufacturing and commercialising products in India"
Market Disclosure

PAK DEAL: 'GUARDIAN 2' IN FOCUS
"Proud to support Pak's Ministry of Defence... Memorandum gives both sides a strategic framework to build upon"
Brett Velicovich, Co-founder of Powerus

Guardian 2 is a more advanced version



Licensing pact signed with Paras Defence to manufacture and sell Guardian 1 interceptors

Manu Pubby

New Delhi: Months before it inked a deal to sell armed drones to Pakistan, an American autonomous systems company, with close links to the sons of President Donald Trump, signed an agreement to manufacture and commercialise anti-drone systems with an Indian company. Newly minted US drone company Powerus, which announced contracts with the Pakistani military after its representatives met Pakistani Army chief Asim Munir last week and sold protection systems to oil and infrastructure entities in the Middle East impacted by the war on Iran, signed a li-

censing agreement to make its 'Guardian' interceptor products in India. According to market disclosures, Paras Defence and Space Technologies entered into an agreement with Powerus Defense in June for an exclusive licence to manufacture and sell its anti-drone systems in India in exchange for a licence fee and share of net profits from sales in India. "Through the agreement, Powerus grants Paras an exclusive licence to use the licensed IP within India for the purpose of 'manufacturing and commercialising products in India,'" the market disclosure said, identifying the product as the 'Guardian 1 Interceptor'. When contacted, Paras Defence said that their representatives are not available for comments. Guardian 1 is described as a high-speed, battery-powered counter-drone system developed by Powerus designed to combat low-cost aerial threats. According to the company, the counter-drone interceptor is designed to take down one-way attack drones like Shahed 136 and Geran 2.



While the licensing deal has been signed, the US-origin equipment has not yet secured an order from Indian armed forces, according to available information. There is a significant demand for anti-drone systems in India, with several companies offering solutions either alone or in partnership with overseas technology suppliers.

In Pakistan, however, a firm order has been placed on Powerus, with the US company making an announcement on Thursday after its representatives met Munir. The company said a limited procurement order has been received from the Pakistani defence ministry for unmanned aerial systems. "We are proud to support Pa-

NO ORDER FROM INDIAN ARMED FORCES YET



While the licensing deal has been signed with Indian co, the US-origin equipment has not yet secured an order from Indian armed forces, according to available information

kistan's Ministry of Defence, and the memorandum gives both sides a strategic framework to build upon," Brett Velicovich, co-founder of Powerus is quoted as saying after a meeting with Munir at Rawalpindi on Wednesday. While it did not name the specific system being sold, a press release featured the photograph of a Guardian 2, which is a more advanced version from its Guardian series of drone interceptors. The US company also said that the order represents an expansion of its overseas business.

A separate MoU has been signed with Pak for cooperation in unmanned and autonomous systems.

TRUMP FAMILY CONNECTION

Powerus, a relatively unknown drone company, is trying to ride on the new tech wave and made its entry with small contracts with the US Air Force and Department of Defence in the last few months. The company is being merged with an entity that operates two golf courses in Florida. Company records show that Donald Trump Junior and Eric Trump are 'notable investors' in the company through their American Venture Partners vehicle. In a statement to Reuters, the company's representatives claimed that the Trump family has no operational control or involvement.

OPPN SLAMS TRUMP Reject US Tariff, Put Trade Deal on Hold: Cong's Sharma to Govt

'It is ironic the US is annually importing uranium and ferts valued over \$4 b'

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Congress has slammed US President Donald Trump for signing the Lindsay Graham bill into an Act that empowers him to impose 100% tariffs on countries, including India, which are buying oil from Russia, and urged the Centre to reject the US push and put on hold the signing of an unequal trade deal with the US until the tariff issues are fully resolved. Maintaining that Trump's "unjustified action" has serious implications for India's energy security, CWC member Anand Sharma, a former commerce minister, said, "Trump's tariff regime and action violate US' own international commitments and undertakings as a member of WTO. A domestic law cannot override US commitment made to WTO. This has been upheld in WTO cases challenging 301 measures taken by the US in the past... It is ironic that the US itself is annually importing uranium and fertilisers valued over \$4 billion. These have been carefully kept out of the ambit of the Graham Act. This is hypocrisy and double standards."



'US will not impose the punitive tariff on NATO members Turkey, Hungary and Slovakia'

Sharma said: "India must firmly reject any such imposition and defend its sovereign independence of trading and economic cooperation with its partner countries. We should put on hold the signing of an unequal trade deal with the US until the tariff issues are fully resolved." Calling the move "selective and discriminatory", Sharma said the US will not impose the punitive tariff on Turkey, Hungary and Slovakia who are NATO members and supporting Ukraine in its war with Russia.



Kashmiri Pandits take part in a procession before immersing an idol of Lord Ganesha in Srinagar's Jhelum river - AP

OPPOSITION AGENDA: GOVERNANCE 'FAILURES', QUOTA, STATEHOOD

NC Pads Up as Oppn Plans to Corner J&K's Omar Govt Over Several Issues

Assembly session starts today; Sunil Sharma: Let them resign if they can't deliver in this set up

Hakeem Irfan Rashid

Srinagar: The autumn session of the Jammu and Kashmir assembly is starting from Monday, with Opposition parties geared up to corner the government over the issues of governance failures, reservation policy and statehood. The opposition BJP, People's Democratic Party, Awami Ittehad Party and the ruling National Conference's alliance partner Congress have stated that they would raise people's issues as the Omar Abdullah-led government has failed to deliver on the promises made to the people of Jammu and Kashmir. BJP, the principal Opposition party in the 90-member assembly with 29 MLAs, plans to raise the



STRATEGY MEETING



Ruling NC held a special meeting of its legislators in Srinagar

outsourcing of government jobs, corruption in public offices and the delay in holding panchayat and urban local bodies' polls. "This government cannot hide behind the excuse that statehood is the solution to all problems. Let them resign if they cannot deliver in this set up... This government has amplified corruption and gives jobs to people recommended by party workers," said

BJP's Sunil Sharma, who is the leader of the Opposition in the assembly. PDP has said that it will focus on unemployment, outsourcing of jobs, the reservation policy and the regularisation of daily wagers in government service. J&K Pradesh Congress Committee president and MLA from Srinagar, Tariq Hameed Karra, said Congress would continue to raise people's genuine concerns in the assembly despite being in an alliance with NC. "We are in alliance with the National Conference, but that does not mean we will not raise public issues. We will take up genuine concerns and ensure they are expedited," said Karra after meeting Congress MLAs. Meanwhile, the ruling NC held a special meeting of its legislators in Srinagar, chaired by party president Farooq Abdullah. The meeting, attended by Omar Abdullah and others, chalked out a strategy for raising public issues, demands and other matters of importance in the assembly. Abdullah urged the MLAs to accord priority to the concerns of the people and highlight the issues and demands of their respective constituencies.

Western Ghats Row: K'taka All-Party Delegation likely to Meet PM; 3-Day Special Session From Today

To convey reservations against declaring parts of Western Ghats as eco-sensitive area

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: Karnataka government plans to take an all-party delegation of MPs and MLAs to meet

Prime Minister Narendra Modi to convey the state's strong reservations against declaring parts of the Western Ghats as eco-sensitive area (ESA). The move comes ahead of a three-day special assembly session starting Monday, where the state will formulate its response to the Centre's latest draft



notification on the Kasturirangan report and review the drought situation. The Centre has sought states' feedback by September 27. Karnataka has consistently opposed the proposed ESA tag, warning that it would adversely impact livelihoods, plantations,

We will first understand the sentiments of the people and farmers, as well as the situation of those living near forest areas before discussing the matter in the House

DK SHIVAKUMAR Karnataka CM

farming communities and infrastructure development across the region. Under the latest draft, the Union government has proposed declaring 20,668 sq km across 10 districts of Karnataka as ecologically sensitive. Earlier, the notification said the move would affect 1,449 villages across 39 taluks. Ahead of the special session, chief minister DK Shivakumar toured key Western Ghats districts, including the coffee-growing region of Sakleshpur in Hassan, to interact with local residents, farmers and legislators. "We will first understand the senti-

ments of the people and farmers, as well as the situation of those living near forest areas before discussing the matter in the House," the CM said.

KASTURIRANGAN PANEL'S SUGGESTION The Kasturirangan panel had recommended designating ecologically fragile pockets of the Western Ghats as ESA to strike a balance between conservation and development. While the draft framework exempts agriculture and plantation activities, it seeks to ban or restrict mining, quarrying and large construction or industrial projects.

OTHER NEWS OF THE DAY

40 Elephants Near Coal Mines Trigger Panic



RAMGARH: A herd of around 40 elephants was found roaming near Central Coalfields Limited mines in Jharkhand's Ramgarh district, triggering panic among miners and villagers and prompting mine managers to step up vigilance to prevent human-animal conflict, a forest department official said on Sunday. The general manager of CCL's Kuju area mines, RK Sinha, said an alert has been sounded for Karma, Ara and Sarubera projects. "Night shift workers have been asked to remain vigilant," he said. Bateshwar Paswan, the forest range officer who led a quick response team on Saturday night, said elephants have been camping in the area and the herd may move to the mines. - PTI



SOME INJURED



A few protesters suffered injuries and were taken to a local hospital: Sr police official

ANOTHER LIFE LOST

Woman Battling Gun Injuries Succumbs



IMPHAL: A 21-year-old woman who sustained gun injuries during a recent attack by armed miscreants died in Manipur's Churachandpur district on Sunday, officials said. Nei Esther Gangte died at the District Hospital Churachandpur after battling critical injuries for 7 days. - PTI

Class 7 Student in Hospital After Attack by Pitbull



FARIDABAD: A pitbull dog attacked a class 7 student in NIT-3, biting him in 16 places, and leaving him seriously wounded, police said on Sunday. His family took him to BK Hospital, where doctors referred him to a higher medical centre. The boy is currently under treatment there. According to a complaint filed by Jitendra, a biryani cat owner, his son, Granth, was out with his cycle and was talking to a friend in front of a house, when a pitbull charged at him. "The dog kept biting my son. The dog's owner made no attempt to save my son. People from the neighbourhood rushed to the spot after hearing cries. The dog was finally separated..." Jitendra alleged in his complaint. - PTI

3 Ps: Pandits, Public & Politicians

Priests are generally expected to act as intermediaries between deities and their worshippers. Although this pastoral bonding has evolved and undergone significant changes over time, the core structure of the relationship has remained constant — priests perform rituals to fulfil the wishes of their patrons, who reward them with daan and dakshina (alms and honorarium). When desires are granted, priests receive praise for their efforts; but if wishes remain unmet, they provide further guidance to the seekers. The process continues until the goal is achieved. But this unwritten code of conduct was recently disturbed in election-bound Uttar Pradesh when a priest was allegedly taken hostage by

two men, who demanded a ransom of ₹1 lakh from his family after their wishes remained unfulfilled following a religious ceremony. Apparently, the accused were seeking the return of ₹1 lakh spent on the ritual. This demand from the duo appears rather strange. What can priests do if gods don't grant blessings? Moreover, priests are chosen by patrons, not the other way around. These two individuals, along with others, can learn from the seasoned politicians of Uttar Pradesh. As elections approach, candidates of all hues have turned to kathavachaks (religious storytellers) for better results. All of them know that outcomes can either be beneficial or unfavourable. Still, one can rest assured that these political pros won't at least hold kathavachaks accountable if



they perform poorly in the assembly polls. Win or lose, they will keep turning to sacred preachers.

Pravir Kumar



IAF CHIEF HAILS JOINT EXERCISE

PTI

In A First, Japanese Fighters Operate From Indian Soil

JODHPUR: Japanese fighter aircraft operating from Indian soil for the first time marks a major milestone in defence cooperation between India and Japan, Air Chief Marshal AP Singh said here on Sunday during an ongoing bilateral air exercise. The exercise, being held at Air Force Station, Jodhpur, from September 9-22, involves Indian Air Force frontline aircraft, including the indigenously Tejas, Su30MKI and Rafale, and Japan Air Self-Defense Force's F2A fighters. Japanese Air Self-Defense Force Chief of Staff General Takehiro Morita said the deployment of Japanese fighters to India had taken defence cooperation beyond simply conducting exercises and demonstrated the ability to deploy air assets across the Indo-Pacific region. The Japanese air chief flew a Tejas jet with a pilot while Air Chief Marshal Singh flew solo on a Tejas jet as part of their sorties under the Indo-Japan bilateral air exercise, Veer Guardian 2026. - PTI



PHOTO JUNCTION

ALLEGES INSULT TO PM'S MOTHER AT CONG EVENT

BJP Attacks Rahul Over Stand-up Act

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: BJP has launched a scathing attack on Rahul Gandhi over a stand-up comedy enacted at the 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' programme in Indore, and sought an apology from him for insulting Prime Minister Narendra Modi's mother and resorting to falsehoods. A political row has erupted after comedian Pulkit Mani mimicked PM Modi's style of greeting international leaders and went on to mimic the way Modi speaks by saying 'Ma' at the Chhatron Ki Goonj programme. Talking to the media on the sidelines of a BJP programme in Fazilka, party's national general secretary Satish Poonia demanded an apology from Gandhi for insulting the PM's mother. Union minister Arjun Ram Meghwal accused Gandhi and his programme of resorting to falsehoods and personal insults. "Look at the way he speaks about the PM's

mother, who is no longer with us. What is the intent behind such insults?" Meghwal told reporters.

Congress leader Raashid Alvi, however, defended Gandhi, saying the act was "mimicry and nothing else" and alleged that the "real insult" was the remarks made by the PM about Sonia Gandhi.



Nagaland SIR: 1.59 Lakh Voters Left Out of Electoral Draft Roll

KOHIMA: Nagaland's draft electoral roll was published on Sunday with nearly 1.59 lakh of the 13.57 lakh voters excluded from the pre-SIR list. The Chief Electoral Officer's office said the draft roll has 11.99 lakh names, with the SIR exercise finding 29,944 electors from the previous list deceased, 1.23 lakh absent or permanently shifted, and 5,059 enrolled at multiple places. The enumeration phase of the SIR of electoral rolls was held in the state from August 16 to September 14. — PTI

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Regional Players Explore Non-BJP, Non-Cong Front

Jatin Takkar

New Delhi: Efforts are being made to bring together non-BJP and non-Congress players at the national and state levels, including in poll-bound Uttar Pradesh. At the national level, DMK has begun reaching out to regional players, with party leader Kanimozhi holding discussions with TMC chief Mamata Banerjee, Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray and NCP(SP) MP Supriya Sule. She has also reached out to several South Indian parties, to bring non-BJP, non-Congress regional forces onto a common platform.

The initiative comes amid changed political equations in Tamil Nadu, where the DMK's ties with Congress have broken down after the latter joined the Vijay-led TVK alliance.

In Uttar Pradesh, a parallel exercise is gathering pace ahead of the assembly elections. AIMIM chief Asaduddin Owaisi, Azad Samaj Party (Kanshiram) chief Chandrashekhar Azad, and former UP minister Swami Prasad Mawrya are discussing a common platform. Sources said an announcement could be made at a Lucknow press conference on September 27, with Apna Dal (Kamerawadi) chief Pallavi Patel also being considered for the alliance.

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PART OF ED'S INVESTIGATION INTO TMC'S FINANCIAL DEALINGS WITH AVIATION COMPANIES

ED Probes TMC's ₹5.22 crore Advance for Aviation Services

Party paid advance for July, August & September services not yet availed of: ED analysis

Raghav Ohri

New Delhi: The Enforcement Directorate is examining advance payments totalling ₹5.22 crore made by the Trinamool Congress for aviation services for July, August and September 2026, even though the services covered by the payments had not yet been availed, people in the know told ET.

The finding forms part of the agency's wider examination of the financial transactions between Trinamool Congress and aviation companies and comes amid an ongoing probe into the alleged routing and utilisation of party funds through Carewell Aviation India Pvt Ltd. According to people quoted above, the party released advance payments aggregating ₹5.22 crore towards aviation services for three months. The agency has recorded that the corresponding services had not been availed at the time of its account analysis. The payment is significant in the context of ED's wider investigation into the party's aviation expenditure. The agency is examining the financial arrangements under which TMC made the pay-

TMC paid about ₹162.09 crore to Carewell Group entities between July 2021 and June 2026, alleges ED



USAGE OF 11-12 HOURS

TMC committed to 150 flying hours over 60 days for a Falcon 2000 but used it for only 11-12 hours, paying ₹9.09 cr: ED

ments to Carewell and other aviation companies, including the source of funds, contractual terms, utilisation of aircraft and movement of money between related entities. ED has alleged that TMC transferred about ₹162.09 crore to Carewell Group entities between July 2021 and June 2026. Its investigation has focused, among other things, on aircraft and helicopter charter arrangements entered into by the party with Carewell Aviation. Under an aircraft charter agreement executed in April 2023, TMC paid an interest-free refundable security deposit of ₹60 crore. A separate helicopter charter

agreement executed in March 2025 involved another refundable deposit of ₹28.5 crore, taking the total deposits to ₹88.5 crore.

The agency is examining these arrangements alongside the subsequent movement of funds through the Carewell group. ED's account analysis also records that ₹133.84 crore received by Carewell was subsequently layered into newly-incorporated related entity Carewell Flyjet IFSC Pvt Ltd in Ahmedabad's GIFT City as inter-corporate loans for the acquisition of an Embraer Legacy 600 aircraft and an Agusta 109 Grand New helicopter.

ED is also examining payments made by TMC to aviation companies other than Carewell. Its analysis includes an instance involving a Falcon 2000 chartered from Windborne Aviation, under which TMC agreed to a minimum 150-hour commitment for 60 days but, according to the note, ultimately used the aircraft for only around 11-12 hours while paying approximately ₹9.09 crore.

RESIDENCES OF EX-MLA, COUNCILLOR AND CPI(M)-BUILT MARTYRS' MEMORIAL TARGETED IN JADAVPUR

TMC Office, Leaders' Homes Vandalised

Our Political Bureau | PTI

Kolkata: A TMC office, the residences of a former MLA and councillor, and a CPI(M)-built martyrs' memorial were allegedly vandalised in south Kolkata's Jadavpur, with the Trinamool Congress and the Left separately accusing BJP workers of involvement, a charge denied by saffron party. Former Jadavpur MLA Debabrata Majumdar on Sunday alleged that his residence at Bijoygarh was attacked by a gro-

up of 100-150 people whom he described as "outsiders" who joined the BJP recently. He claimed that the group, allegedly carrying arms, moved through several areas on motorcycles on Saturday night and vandalised TMC party offices and other places before reaching his residence, where they allegedly pelted stones and broke window panes. Former TMC councillor of ward 96 Basundhara Goswami alleged that her house was also ransacked by

members of a motorcycle-borne group. She claimed that the group was armed and carried BJP flags. "The BJP is trying to terrorise opposition parties, but they cannot keep us indoors," she said.

A TMC office at Bagha Jatin was allegedly ransacked, with party flags found lying on the ground and a memorial dedicated to party workers damaged.

In Anandapalli, a TMC party flag was allegedly torn, and a CPI(M) memorial dedicated to martyrs of the 1960s was vandalised, the party alleged.

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LATE BIBEK DEBROY APPEARS IN LIST OF VOTERS BEING ISSUED NOTICES

Delhi CM, EC Sandhu, Advani, Jaishankar Get SIR Notices for 'Discrepancies' in Voter Details

Our Political Bureau | PTI

New Delhi: Former deputy PM LK Advani, external affairs minister S Jaishankar, former vice-president Jagdeep Dhankhar and Election Commissioner SS Sandhu are among the many prominent figures in the list of voters who have been issued notices for "discrepancies" in their details furnished under the SIR exercise, officials said on Sunday. Delhi CM Rekha Gupta and AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal have also been issued notices, officials said.

After publication of draft rolls of over 97 lakh voters under the SIR, 33.13 lakh notices were being issued over "discrepancies" in details furnished by people in their enumeration forms. Most notices were issued for voter details not matching with the information in the last SIR in 2002. The Delhi Chief Electoral Officer's office, however, maintained that system-generated notices were being issued to voters with discrepancies to correct their data in ECINET and stressed that "there is no existential crisis as is being brought out in social and print". **Election Commissioner SS Sandhu has been issued a notice over a**

mismatch in his name, while his son Damanbir has been served a notice over a mismatch in his parent's name.

Those who have already been issued notice or who are to be issued one soon include foreign secretary Vikram Misri, ex-Delhi Deputy CM Manish Sisodia, former JNU VC M Jagadesh Kumar, ex-LG Najeeb Jung, officials said.

The name of late economist and former chairman of Prime Minister's Economic Advisory Council Bibek Debroy also appeared in the list of voters being issued notices for "discrepancies". Debroy died in November 2024.

DEATH BY SUICIDE OF 2ND-YEAR STUDENT AT IIT-BOMBAY

Mumbai Crime Branch Takes Over IIT-B Student Death Probe

Family alleges Sahil faced caste-based harassment; absolutely no substance in this allegation: Director

Our Political Bureau

Mumbai: Mumbai Crime Branch has taken over the probe into the suicide of a second-year IIT Bombay student.

On Friday, Sahil Wakode (20), a second-year student of the Department of Energy Science and Engineering, was found dead in his hostel room, hours after he was caught using a mobile phone during an examination. Wakode had allegedly uploaded the examination paper on an AI platform to seek answers, the institute had said in its statement. However, his family has registered a complaint alleging that their son was subjected to mental torture by a faculty member and caste-based harassment that "drove him to end his life". "... the paperwork has been handed over to the crime branch and an investigation is underway. The probe will ascertain if the suicide was due to him being caught during the exam or if he was subjected to caste-based harassment as alleged," a senior police officer told ET.

According to the complaint reviewed by ET, Sahil had told his father that faculty member Suryanarayana Doola had allegedly been abusing him with caste-related slurs and harassing him for around three months. The father has alleged that the faculty member was acting on the instructions of senior officials. An FIR has been filed against Doola and unknown senior officials under section 108 of BNS pertaining to

Police personnel stand guard as students protest following the death of a 20-year-old student in Mumbai - PTI

abatement of suicide and certain sections of the Prevention of Atrocities Act.

Ravindra Chavan Wakode said his son had expressed apprehension that he could be implicated in a minor matter. Ravindra Wakode has alleged that the faculty member's conduct amounted to mental harassment and drove his son to take the extreme step.

IIT Bombay, in a statement issued on Saturday, said the student had died by suicide on the previous evening. The institute said earlier that day, during an examination, the student was found using a mobile phone in the exam hall and had uploaded the examination question paper on ChatGPT to seek answers. The institute said no disciplinary action had been initiated against the student. According to its statement, the matter was discussed with him by the instructor, faculty adviser and Head of the Department, who counselled him and assured him that the incident would not adversely affect his

POLICE PROBE
Investigation will ascertain whether the death was linked to the exam incident or alleged caste harassment: Police

academic career. The student subsequently returned to his hostel room and was later found dead there, the institute said. The institute said the circumstances surrounding the death were being looked into by the appropriate authorities.

When contacted, IIT Bombay Director Professor Shireesh Kedare denied allegations of caste-based discrimination on the campus. **There is absolutely no substance in this allegation," Kedare said, adding that the institute had a policy of non-discrimination.** Kedare said, so far, no complaint of caste-based discrimination by Sahil had come to his knowledge during the three months referred to by the family in their allegations. "... I will hold a discussion with students on Monday regarding the incident and if required, would tender my resignation," he told ET.

Implications Clearly Put Across

►► From Page 1

It may also be taken up during US secretary of state Marco Rubio's India trip in October.

Jaishankar will be in New York for meetings at the United Nations. His address at the high-level session of the 81st United Nations General Assembly is scheduled for September 26. During the visit, the minister will also attend various plurilateral and bilateral meetings. Rubio will be in New York during September 20-23 for the UN General Assembly meeting.

"China will find a way out to continue to import Russian oil, notwithstanding any sanctions," said the person cited above. Beijing may even retaliate against any US move to impose tariffs on it.

Chinese President Xi Jinping will be visiting Washington DC this week for a summit and may be received by Trump at Joint Base Andrews, just outside Washington. US Presidents usually welcome visiting foreign leaders directly at the White House rather than at an airport. The last time this happened was in 1959 when Dwight Eisenhower received Soviet leader Nikita Khrushchev at the height of the Cold War as both sides sought to manage ties.

The external affairs ministry had issued a strongly worded statement last week after the US Congress passed the bill. "This issue has been discussed at high levels in recent months with various US

interlocutors. Its potential implications for not just the bilateral relationship but also the international energy market have been very clearly articulated by the Indian side," it had said. "We are monitoring further developments. As stated on several earlier occasions, India remains firmly committed to ensuring energy security for its 1.4 billion people. It will continue to do so through diversified sourcing and on the basis of evolving market dynamics."

The Indian government has made clear its determination to take all necessary measures to protect its trade and economic interests. The government will work closely with Indian trade and industry groupings to deal with the implications of these developments, the statement said, in the backdrop of the trade pact being negotiated with the US.

The Graham Act, passed by the US Senate last month, was approved by the House in a 262-159 vote last Wednesday. Last year, Trump had imposed 25% tariffs on India for purchasing Russian oil, but later withdrew it as trade deal negotiations with India progressed.

Russia continues to be India's number one oil supplier. India imported 2.08 million barrels per day (bpd) of Russian oil in August. Moscow's share in New Delhi's crude imports was 45% in August. India will be an official partner at the Russia Energy Week exposition in Moscow next month.

Karnataka FDA Uncovers ₹5-cr Worth Fake Drugs

Bengaluru: Karnataka's Food Safety and Drug Administration (FDA) has uncovered an alleged unlicensed pharmaceutical repackaging and relabelling operation at a farmhouse in Bidadi, with spurious drugs, machinery and printing material worth about ₹5.05 crore seized during a raid on August 18.

The department, which is conducting a series of raids on orders from new health and family welfare minister UT Khader, has also initiated action against retailers and wholesalers allegedly linked to the distribution and sale of spurious drugs. The licences of 16 entities have been cancelled and those of eight others suspended, according to an FDA statement.

The licence of Pfizer C&F Depot at Kempalinganahalli in Nelamangala taluk, Bengaluru Rural district, also figures among the licenses suspended.

The FDA's Drug Enforcement Wing conducted joint inspection following a tip-off at a farmhouse in Kurubarakaranahalli in Bengaluru South district.

Preliminary findings suggest the premises were allegedly used to procure low-cost medicines from neighbouring states, repackaging them and relabel them as expensive life-saving drugs. —Our Bureau

Litigation Costs may Come in Focus

►► From Page 1

Tata Trusts could seek to challenge the validity of the resolution passed by the Tata Sons board last Thursday, said people aware of developments. The move to approach the higher court will be on the basis of majority shareholders' rights, they said.

Tata Trusts is expected to fund the legal costs of any litigation arising from the ongoing dispute. People familiar with the matter said the Trusts has, in the past, passed resolutions providing for litigation-related expenses, and is adequately insured to cover such costs.

However, two key trustees, Vijay Singh and Venu Srinivasan, are understood not to have signed such resolutions, taking the view that any legal matter involving the Trusts should be considered on a case-by-case basis, people aware of the matter said. The issue could assume significance as the Trusts prepares to challenge the board's decision on Chandrasekaran's reappointment and seeks legal intervention to maintain the status quo, said the people cited.

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has already filed a caveat petition in the Bombay High Court, asking to be heard in case Tata Trusts seeks relief against the regulator's directive on the listing of Tata Sons.

At the Tata Sons board meeting last week, a majority of the members voted in fa-

vour of listing and Chandrasekaran's reappointment as chairman.

Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata had opposed both resolutions. This triggered a broader disagreement between Tata Trusts and Tata Sons over the validity of board resolutions, conditions attached to voting and the interpretation of the company's Articles of Association.

Ashish Bhakta, founding partner of law firm ANB Legal, said Tata Trusts will be weighing options on challenges. "While NCLT would be the natural jurisdiction to seek relief under the Companies Act and halt the board's decisions to confirm the extension of Chandrasekaran's reappointment on the board of Tata Sons, to approach the Supreme Court in the circumstances available to the public seems plausible only by invoking the writ jurisdiction under Article 32," said Bhakta. "The constitution bench in Kaushal Kishor has held that a writ lies against a party who is not a state if the fundamental rights under Articles 19 and 21 stand breached. Accordingly, it would be interesting to see which provisions are being invoked."

This means writ petitions can be filed against non-state entities if fundamental rights under Articles 19 or 21 are regarded to be violated.

Himanshu Vidhani, founding partner of law firm Quadra Legal, said NCLT was the appropriate forum. "Tata Sons, for its

part, has no reason to move any forum at all. Its only real regulatory exposure is before the Bombay High Court on RBI's rejection, and RBI has already filed a caveat there," said Vidhani. "Albeit it will be a respondent in any case filed by Tata Trusts in any court such as the Supreme Court, Bombay High Court or even NCLT."

Senior counsel Abhishek Manu Singhvi, representing Tata Trusts, posted on X that the fundamental rights of shareholder-owners cannot be nullified in the manner in which they have been.

"Rupturing over a hundred years of Tata Trusts and Tata Sons established hyphenated relationship and divorcing one from the other seems unthinkable," he said on Sunday. "Ignoring the unvarying precondition of Trust unanimity in voting, and the clear veto in provisions applied without caveat for decades, appears patently unjustified."

The Supreme Court judgement in the Tata-Mistry case clearly gave Tata Trusts primacy in the relationship with Tata Sons, said Singhvi. It also "upheld the special Articles in this regard in the Tata Sons articles and spoke of the fiduciary duty to millions of Indians," he said.

Senior counsel Harish Salve, backing the Tata Sons chairman, has described Tata Sons' legal position as "legally perfect," asserting that the company must comply with RBI regulations, which include becoming a public company.

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Move comes amid a ramp-up of focus on the luxury segment

Anumeha Chaturvedi

New Delhi: Chalet Hotels is in advanced discussions to finalise the acquisition of the luxury wellness retreat Six Senses Vana in Dehradun for around ₹600 crore, people familiar with the matter told ET. Max Group founder Analjit Singh's son Veer Singh is the owner of the Dehradun property managed by luxury brand Six Senses. Analjit Singh had gifted Vana to his son as part of a succession and inheritance plan, people familiar with the matter said. Analjit Singh and Chalet Hotels did not respond to requests for comment until press time Sunday. Veer Singh could not be reached for comment. The Six Senses brand comes under the portfolio of UK-based IHG Hotels & Resorts.

Chalet Hotels, part of the K Raheja Corp group, has been ramping up its focus on the luxury segment. Chief executive Shwetank Singh told ET in February that the company was launching its first Ritz Carlton property, a 330-room luxury hotel project along with commercial or retail space, in Hyderabad. Last year, Chalet Hotels said it was in the process of entering into a definitive agreement with Mankind Pharma for a 100% stake in Mahananda Spa and Resorts, the company that owns The Westin Resort and Spa, Himalayas in Rishikesh, at an enterprise value of ₹530 crore. In December, Chalet Hotels said it would acquire a company owning a 150-room resort property in Udaiपुर for ₹171 crore. Chalet Hotels is also constructing a hotel at the Delhi airport to be managed by Indian Hotels company under the Taj brand.

In his interaction with ET in February, CEO Singh said Chalet Hotels had a "very deep belief" in the premiation of its offerings, be it residential or commercial projects. "Our data points tell us that these are the segments where most of the growth will come from. All our future announcements will be driven by this belief," he said.

AS SECOND-HOME DEMAND LOSES STEAM

Goa's Real Estate Enters Correction Phase

Mid-segment properties face slower sales, while those at the premium and entry-level hold steady

Faizan Haider

New Delhi: Goa's real estate market is undergoing a correction, with experts describing it as a stabilisation rather than a crash as sales and enquiries for second homes slow considerably. The post-Covid surge in demand from high-net-worth individuals (HNIs) and second-home buyers brought significant new capital and developers into the state. But momentum has shifted over the past year, with buyers taking longer to conclude high-value transactions. North Goa saw a 4-6% price correction in H1 2026, following years of overheated, frenzy-driven growth. Smart capital is moving out of saturated hotspots like As-



sagao and Candolim into emerging pockets such as Moira and Nerul, where entry points are more attractive and land parcels remain available at scale," said Shweta Jain, managing director-residential services, Savills India. Residential plots in the 250-350 sq m category continue to account for a significant share of unsold inventory across the primary and secondary markets, highlighting a persistent demand-supply mismatch. As a result, many developers have adopted more flexible pricing strategies to accelerate sales, putting downward pressure on capital values. "There is some correction in Goa's re-

sidential market after a six-year bull run. But the correction is largely at the mid-level segment end, in the ₹5-10 crore segment, after a couple of overheated years. In that segment, villas and apartment projects are seeing slower sales while entry level and premium properties are seeing steady velocity," said Karan Singh, area director (Goa), India Sotheby's International Realty. However, demand remains strong for differentiated homes, including properties with prime sea views, riverfront or hill locations, smaller curated villa communities and projects with the right amenities. Tamnay Kholkar, founder of Manas Developers, said Goa saw an influx of capital and developers post-Covid as HNI and second-home demand surged. "In the rush to meet this demand, inventory expanded rapidly in certain pockets, while land prices in select micro-markets rose by as much as fivefold, moving well ahead of the infrastructure and fundamentals supporting that growth. We are now seeing some moderation in these asking prices, with land values in certain pockets moderating by 20-25%," said Kholkar.

Hindi No Longer a Prerequisite for Regional Films' Box-Office Success

Changing OTT economics helping culturally rooted stories reach wider audiences

Rajesh N Naidu

Mumbai: Several local language movies that scored financial success in the past two years, particularly those focused on their home audience and not the Hindi market, reflect a course correction in the way regional films are conceived. After a series of failed attempts at creating pan-India films by relying on stardom, scale and Hindi dubbing, regional movies are increasingly

focusing on their core audience, and if the content is strong, they travel across markets, said exhibitors, producers and distributors. The rising focus of streaming platforms on box-office success as a key criterion in digital rights valuation, universal appeal of culturally rooted stories and reasonably good awareness of regional cinema have contributed to the notable successes of regional films across markets, they said. Films such as *Bethlehem Kudumba*

Unit (Malayalam), *Irumudi* (Telugu), *Deool Band 2* (Marathi), *Tourist Family* (Tamil), *Su From So* (Kannada) and *Laalo* (Gujarati) recorded massive successes without Hindi dubbing. *Bethlehem Kudumba Unit*, made on a budget of less than ₹25 crore, collected ₹156 crore in India alone. Increasingly, digital platforms are taking content-oriented films in any language into the spotlight. This has added to success stories of regional films across languages, said exhibitors. "Today, good content in any language travels, thanks to the active global digital network of audiences. Well-made regional films have benefited from this. Even a small-budget film, *Hanuman Ansh*, has travelled and is doing well even in Australia, New Zealand and the US," said Devang Sampat, managing director at movie-theatre chain Cinepolis India. These regional films have performed well without Hindi distribution. "The box-office performance of recent regional films has shown that Hindi distribution is an opportunity for expansion and not a prerequisite for success," said Suniel Wadhwa, co-founder and director at film production and distribution company Karmic Films.

REGIONAL FILMS PERFORMING WITHOUT HINDI DISTRIBUTION					
IRUMUDI (Telugu)	BETHLEHEM* (Kannada)	SU FROM SO (Kannada)	DEOOL BAND 2 (Marathi)	LAALO (Gujarati)	TOURIST FAMILY (Tamil)
₹35-50 cr	Less than ₹25 cr	Less than ₹3 cr	₹8-10 cr	₹50 Lakh	Less than ₹7 cr
187.4	122.0	92.3	74.4	97.1	61.6
240.1	235.4	122.8	87.1	122.3	87.0
■ BUDGET ■ INDIA NET (₹CR) ■ WORLDWIDE GROSS (₹CR)					

*Bethlehem Kudumba Unit
Source: Sacnilk, Trade analysts

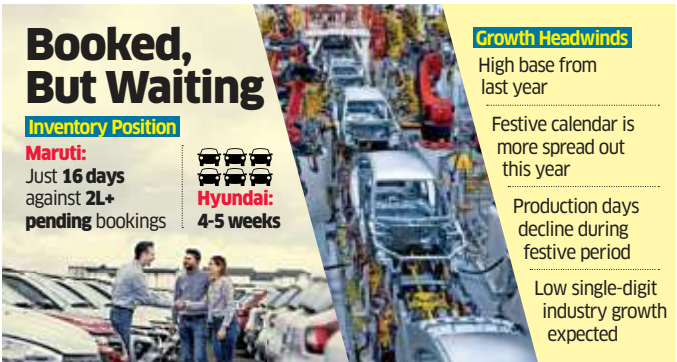
GROWTH AHEAD, SPEED BUMPS TOO

Auto Cos Have Demand, But Lean Stocks Could Dent Festive Show

Makers are upbeat about sales, but a high base and supply crunch could keep growth in check

Shally Seth Mohile & Sharmistha Mukherjee

Mumbai | New Delhi: Low levels of stocks at dealerships could weigh on car sales this festive season, with the top five manufacturers that account for more than 85% of the market struggling to build inventory even as bookings remain strong. The second leg of the festive season, starting with Navratri on October 11 and through Diwali on November 10, is expected to be positive from a demand perspective, but companies may not be able to fully make use of that because of supply constraints, said industry executives. This one-month period is crucial for automakers, as it accounts for a third of their annual sales. Market leader Maruti Suzuki has pending bookings for more than



200,000 units, while its network inventory is currently enough to last only around 16 days of sales compared with the stock for roughly one month it typically carries during the festive period. "At the beginning of this financial year, we had 13 days of stock. Even now we are having 16 days of network stock, and our pending booking is now more than 200,000. We don't see that (having a full month of stock) till December," said Partho Banerjee, senior executive officer, marketing and sales. The company's new automated production lines

are expected to stabilise fully by December, he said. Maruti's sales have grown 35% so far this fiscal year, compared with around 30% industry growth between April and August. Banerjee said vehicle availability would be a key factor in the second half of the fiscal year, as production days decline during the festive period. "To be able to unlock the full potential of the festive season, we need to build inventory which seems to be a challenge this year. We are finding it tough to meet demand even for regular months," said a top executive at

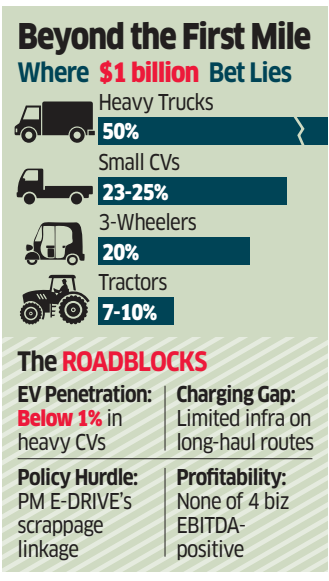
another automaker. While sales in August and so far in September were higher, October and November could be challenging, the executive said. The industry, therefore, may have to contend with low single-digit growth over last year for the season, he said. The festive calendar is more spread out this year, with Onam in August, Ganesh Chaturthi in September and Navratri, Dussehra and Diwali during October-November. Last year, Navratri, Dussehra and Diwali were concentrated in October, making year-on-year comparisons less straightforward this season. Hyundai Motor India has four-five weeks of inventory heading into the second half of the festive season and is advancing the commissioning of a third shift at its Talegaon plant in Maharashtra ahead of the launch of a midsize SUV next month. "Industry growth is expected to taper off and close at about 5-6% in the second half of the fiscal, on a high base. We expect to grow faster than the market with our two new launches," said Hyundai Motor India managing director Tarun Garg.

Montra Bets on Heavy Electric Trucks to Hit \$1-b Revenue Milestone by 2030

Shally Seth Mohile

Mumbai: Montra Electric, the Murugappa Group company that makes electric commercial vehicles, expects nearly 70% of its targeted \$1 billion (around ₹9,600 crore) revenue by 2030 to come from electric trucks, including heavy and light vehicles, managing director Jalaj Gupta told ET. About half the targeted turnover would come from heavy trucks, with small commercial vehicles in the 2.0- to 3.5-tonne segment contributing another 23-25%, he said. Three-wheelers are expected to account for about 20% and 7-10% by tractors. The company is confident of the growth despite penetration of e-trucks in heavy commercial vehicles remaining below 1%, with limited charging infrastructure on

long-haul routes and most electric trucks operating on short, predictable routes. Montra manufactures electric three-wheelers, tractors, small commercial vehicles and heavy trucks, with around 21,000 vehicles on the road. It posted ₹740 crore of revenue last year. Gupta said increasing battery capacities could help overcome range constraints. "There was a time when it all started with some 250-kilowatt batteries. Now everybody is talking of at least 350- to 400-kilowatt batteries," he said. Battery packs in the 450-kWh range that are showcased at industry events could deliver around 300 km on a single charge, he added. He flagged the scrappage-linked



structure of the government's PM E-Drive, which gives upfront subsidies for the purchase of e-trucks against scrapped diesel trucks, as a hurdle for the industry. "The linkage to the scrappage certificate... is where the challenge has been," he said, noting that vehicle scrapping remained voluntary. He estimated scrappage under the scheme for N2 and N3 trucks around 3,400-3,500 vehicles over three years. Industry sales of electric N3 trucks (having gross vehicle weight of more than 12-55 tonnes) rose from about 850 units last fiscal year to around 1,300 in the first five months of the current year, driven by state EV policies, sector-specific deployments in cement and steel, and higher diesel and CNG prices, Gupta said. He expects more than 50% annual growth in electric heavy trucks and small commercial vehicles in coming years.

Logistics Firms Bulk Up Hiring, Capacity to Carry Heavier Festival Loads

Forum Gandhi

Mumbai: India's logistics companies are preparing for a surge in shipment volumes by up to 20% and hiring of temporary workers by as much as 60% this festive season, as e-commerce and quick-commerce companies push more goods through delivery networks. DTDC expects consignments handled by it to increase about 14-15% by volume and 18-20% by weight in the 15 days before Diwali, compared with the same period last year. Seasonal and temporary hiring is projected to increase 60%. Blue Dart expects B2B shipments to rise 40-50% during peak weeks and B2C volumes to roughly double, said chief commercial officer Dipanjan Banerjee. The faster increase in shipment weight than parcel volumes points to higher capacity requirements for sorting, transportation and warehousing, said industry executives. Rising wages are adding to the cost of handling the parcels. "Festive demand is shaping up to be notably stronger than what we saw last year," said Abhinav Singh, vice-president of operations at Amazon India, APAC, Middle East, Türkiye and Africa. Amazon has created more than 160,000 seasonal work opportunities across 400 Indian cities. It has also added 20 fulfilment centres, six sorting centres and 150 last-mile delivery stations ahead of the festive season, increasing storage capacity by 50% to 64 million cubic feet. DTDC said seasonal wages and incentives have increased 18-20% in metropolitan markets and 10-12%



in non-metros from last year. "There is naturally an upward movement in seasonal compensation as the market tightens during the holidays," DTDC said, adding that automation and workforce productivity would help offset the need for additional manpower. Blue Dart expects front-end operational staffing to increase 30-50% from business-as-usual levels, with additional workers in variable roles running into the thousands. "We have strengthened capacity across critical areas through infrastructure enhancements, technology-led planning, workforce augmentation, and operational realignment," Banerjee said.

Hero Arm Tessolve in Talks to Buy Two More Chip Cos; Eyes \$500 m Revenue

New Delhi: Semiconductor engineering services firm Tessolve, a Hero Electronix venture, is in active talks to acquire two more companies—one based in the US and another in India—as it targets annual revenue of over \$500 million within the next three to four years, its co-founder and chief executive Srinu Chinamilli said. "We are in active talks with some companies we have not yet announced... We are talking to one company in the US, and there is one local (Indian) company as well," Chinamilli said, without naming the companies involved. One of the de-

als is expected to close in the next couple of months, while the other is likely to be completed by the end of the current fiscal year, he said. Most of Tessolve's acquisitions are aimed at adding capabilities or geographic presence, rather than purely boosting revenue, Chinamilli said. Its most recent acquisition, Germany-based chip design firm Dream Chip Technologies, has "more than doubled" its revenue since being acquired in 2024, he said. — PTI

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Dollars No Longer Buy Happiness

Global affairs turn consumers glum in Trump 2.0

US consumer sentiment is cratering but, oddly enough, spending is barreling on. This has perplexed economists who are ascribing a variety of factors for this divergence. The latest insight is offered by Goldman Sachs, which claims non-economic factors have led to unusually high pessimism since the Covid epidemic. Other views agree that happiness and financial well-being are decoupling in the US. Consumers have become sceptical about world affairs even though their incomes are rising. And they don't have faith in institutions to set right all that is affecting the world. That can be read as the failure of political leadership, and it won't be too far out of line under a second Trump administration.

The proximate factors affecting consumer spending are inflation and the cost of living, job market stability, household indebtedness and interest rates, and the level of savings. A wider set of parameters defines consumer sentiment, which includes whether newspaper headlines are particularly grim about economic prospects, the popularity ratings of incumbent governments, and trust in public institutions. This second set of non-economic variables appears to consistently override the economic determinants of consumer sentiment that the University of Michigan has been tracking since 1946. It could possibly explain why consumer sentiment has not recovered to its pre-pandemic level.

Other explanations abound. McKinsey suggests that consumers are economising on lower-value purchases and splurging on big-ticket items like holidays and gizmos. One way to get a hang of the consumer's mind would be to break them into smaller groups by age, income and other relevant metrics. This might paint granular pictures that can be scaled up into a population-wide indicator. Otherwise, the US consumer sentiment index will incongruously dwell at levels that have traditionally signalled oncoming economic crises. That doesn't serve much purpose as an indicator. Particularly an indicator that the rest of the world tracks.

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Klopp Plan to Reclaim National Pride & Flag

Jürgen Klopp, Germany's men's national football coach and unofficial minister for common sense, has ventured into territory considerably more treacherous than a high defensive line: patriotism. Germans, he has recently argued, should reclaim national pride from the 'wrong people'. He wants to 'reclaim the flag', so that waving it need not provoke suspicions of extremism in a country with a tricky 'national socialist' past.

Klopp's argument — coming in the backdrop of the far-right Alternative for Germany's (AfD) win in the recent state election in Saxony-Anhalt, making it a contender to form the first far-right government in post-WW2 Germany — is applicable beyond his country. While his statement can be countered by the prevalent fashionable moral relativism of all national pride merely being the same tribal instinct wearing different hats, it isn't. There is healthy patriotism and unhealthy patriotism, and distinguishing them is less difficult than nervous liberals may pretend. Good patriotism says: 'I love my country.' Bad patriotism adds: 'Therefore, you mustn't.' The former regards the flag as an invitation to belong, not proof that somebody else doesn't. The latter, by contrast, requires enemies, turning nationality from affection into certification.

Patriotism is a feeling, not a compliance department. Klopp's 'positive patriotism' — pride compatible with openness, diversity and compassion — is a model that makes taking pride in a nation (or region, city, locality) an attractive celebratory proposition. The larger lesson applicable to such 'belonging' is this: flags, anthems, histories shouldn't be abandoned to those who shout loudest about them. Patriotism is far too important to be left to professional agenda-driven patriots.

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JUST IN JEST

Where our awe-excitement and fear-contempt for AI comes from

A New Smarty-Pants Is Here in the Class

Smartness has always left the mob intimidated and impressed at the same time. Thus the judgemental term 'smart-ass'. Today's over-smart chap in the room is AI. Exceptional intelligence produces something unsettling: suspicion that while you are talking, somebody's already three thought processes ahead. Nobody particularly wants this sort fired. But nobody wants to sit beside him either. AI has now become this 'smarty-pants' raised to planetary scale. Hence the curious cocktail of awe, excitement, gush, paranoia and fear around it. This explains why our response to AI has quickly jumped from 'This thing is remarkably clever, I want to be its BFF' to 'This thing will destroy civilisation next Tuesday'. No one seems to worry that the stupid will destroy civilisation. Although a peek through an Oval Office window suggests it deserves monitoring.

The deeper discomfort is status. Humans have spent millennia congratulating themselves on being Earth's smartest species. Intelligence was our private club, and we owned the premises. Now, something has appeared at the door carrying no schoolbag, requesting no salary, and apparently knowing calculus and Dhammapada. Perhaps AI will transform civilisation. Perhaps it'll disappoint spectacularly. But it *has* committed the oldest social offence: it's made the rest of us in the class feel a little thick.

Bengal needs unambiguous intention to build industry, rather than perform shallow politics

DAS KAPITAL FORMATION



Subhamoy Maitra

Under BJP, West Bengal is once again debating how to put land together for industry. The debate has now acquired a distinctly technical vocabulary: acquisition, negotiated purchase and land pooling.

The three mechanisms are not interchangeable. Acquisition involves compulsory purchase under a statutory framework. Negotiated purchase relies on agreement between landowner and purchaser. Land pooling allows owners to contribute land to a development scheme and receive a smaller, but serviced, and potentially more valuable plot in return. The choice, as recent policy discussions suggest, should depend on the *nature* of the project.

For Bengal, the question of land has always been inseparable from the question of industrialisation. So, the new discussion raises a more fundamental question: even if Bengal succeeds in solving the problem of industrial land, will it succeed in attracting capital? Land can be assembled through legislation, negotiation or planning. But capital can only be attracted through confidence. Excitement surrounding political change is understandable. Bengal has always regarded politics not merely as a mechanism of governance but also as a form of public entertainment. Movement of legislators from one camp to another has become a spectator sport.

Capital, however, follows a different script. It's largely indifferent to the daily theatre of politics, and far more concerned with the stability of institutions. Consider an entrepreneur planning a large investment. The questions are surprisingly simple. Not whether the government is Left, Right or Centre. Not whether ministers speak Bengali, Hindi or English. Not whether people will eat veg or non-veg food. Not whether one political camp will replace another in controlling campuses, institutions or public spaces. The real question is: will rules that exist today survive tomorrow? That confidence in



Song of the roadmap

the durability of institutions is what economists and investors describe as institutional credibility.

It is in this context that the new government's willingness to reconsider how industrial land is assembled becomes significant. Bengal has already begun examining land pooling, industrial parks, and changes to landholding and land-utilisation rules. The government is also considering ways of making large contiguous parcels available without directly acquiring individual agricultural plots.

This is important because Bengal's problem is not simply a shortage of land. It's a shortage of large, contiguous and legally usable parcels of land. Fragmented holdings, overlapping claims and restrictions on land use can make an apparently simple industrial project extraordinarily complicated.

Earlier attempts to create land banks from idle public sector land ran into precisely this problem: available parcels were often too small or too fragmented for large investors. Indeed, there are now signs of movement from policy to implementation. The government has cleared land for 33 industries, and that the land will be handed over before Durga Puja. This is significant. But the real test will be whether these allocations translate into timely project execution, employment and

sustained private investment.

Land pooling could be a useful solution. But it's not a magic wand. Bengal has laws that allow land to be reorganised for development. What matters now is whether these provisions can be implemented effectively, with clear rules on ownership, compensation, infrastructure and land use. Land pooling may bring plots together. But it cannot make ownership disputes disappear.

And this is where the land question meets the question of capital. Corruption is costly. But uncertainty can be even more so. Investors can price an

The government has cleared land for 33 industries scheduled to be handed over before Durga Puja. But the real test will be whether these allocations translate into timely project execution, employment and sustained private investment

unofficial cost. It's much harder to price changing rules, administrative discretion and unpredictable policy.

There's also a geographical reality. Large, contiguous parcels are rarely available near Bengal's major cities. So, industry may have to move farther out, where land disputes and infrastructure gaps can be greater. Industrialists, therefore, need to look beyond quick returns and become partners in building these new industrial regions with the government. Given Bengal's political history, industrialisation cannot be reduced to capitalist extraction alone. It must also create a stake for local communities.

Capital has no ideology. But it has an excellent memory. Two decades ago, large sections of Bengal's political class mobilised against industrial projects in Singur and Nandigram. Today, many of those political actors either constitute an important part of the new political establishment, or have moved into entirely different political formations.

One may celebrate or criticise this phenomenon. But it deserves analysis rather than outrage. The human mind, after all, is a time-variant function. Mathematics teaches us that important variables seldom remain constant. Political preferences are no exception. The objective function of a leader in opposition differs from that of the same leader in government. In electoral democracy, opposition rewards agitation, while government rewards investment; employment and revenue suddenly become governing responsibilities rather than campaign slogans.

Consequently, it may be unnecessary to ask whether politicians have become different human beings. The more relevant question is whether the institutional incentives under which they operate have changed.

Many of the



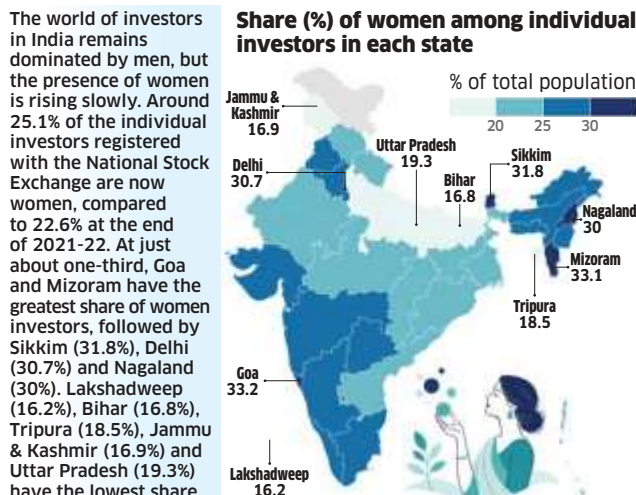
legal instruments required for assembling industrial land already exist. Creating another set of laws, by itself, will not rebuild West Bengal's industrial land bank. What is required is an unambiguous intention to build industry rather than perform shallow politics. The Left Front came to power in 1977 with a clear intention to pursue land reform for the landless. Today, the era, ideology and people are different. Will the new industrial agenda reflect genuine intent? Or will it be merely political rhetoric?

The writer is professor, Indian Statistical Institute, Kolkata

ChatGPT SHAIRI OF THE DAY

Two bigwigs,
Don Trump and Mr Xi,
Are to meet this week over
cookies and tea.
Expectations are so low,
That no matter how things go,
They can claim a
'historic victory'.

MAPPING INDIA'S WOMEN INVESTORS



MEME'S THE WORD



A Tariffs Switch, Again



Seema Sirohi

In the ongoing series called Nasty Surprises from Washington, the latest is Donald Trump's ability to impose up to 100% tariffs on India and other top buyers of Russian oil. It doesn't mean he would. But the sword will hang over the relationship since it's the law. And it passed with bipartisan votes, no less.

Pushback from MEA was the strongest yet, after the House of Representatives voted for the Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act, making the uncertain into the inevitable. India will do what it must to ensure energy security for 1.4 bn people — it will source oil from where it can without thumbing its nose. With Russian and Iranian oil out of easy reach, large buyers' hunt for oil will impact prices in other countries, including the US. 'Potential implications' are immense.

'Sources' have begun raising doubts whether Narendra Modi would still attend the G20 summit in Florida in December. It would depend on what happens between now and then. The 'almost done' trade deal may go up in smoke if Trump decides to use his newly endowed power to impose higher tariffs on Indian exports.

Over the past months, Indian diplomats aggressively engaged both Capitol Hill and the Trump regime as the bill began to take shape to emphasise that the pile of negatives in the India-US relationship shouldn't be allowed to grow or the core will melt. Some of it already has, despite best efforts.

The new law is Trump's very own hammer, authorised by the US Congress to be used when he wants and how he wants. The legal power vested in him is greater and more secure from court

challenges. Silver lining: he can give a waiver, and a waiver is not time-limited, and the bill has a sunset clause of 5 yrs.

Interestingly, Trump was indifferent to the idea of a sanctions bill last year when the late senator Lindsey Graham, a Republican hawk, was pushing it as a way to force Vladimir Putin's hand. Trump didn't want to be forced to act against Russia. He wanted flexibility, and White House lawyers apparently played a major role in the drafting of the current bill, a job normally done within the Congress.

Graham died in July and Russia hawks on the Democratic side saw an opportunity to push the bill. It may be hard for Indians to imagine the deep and abiding aversion of the US establishment towards Russia. Trump is actually an exception and, thus, his demand for a law that suits him. US Congress complied, abdicating its role as a constraint on executive power.

What changed Trump's indifference to interest? Short answer: real possibility of Republicans losing the House in November. He likely heard grim stories from party members at the Republican Midterm Convention in Dallas earlier this month, and realised it was now or never. Speaker Mike Johnson was asked to urgently bring the bill to the House floor. Johnson obeyed, ignoring all Congressio-

nal processes and niceties. There was no review by an appropriate House committee, and no debate before the vote.

While Republican members lying supine before Trump wasn't a surprise, 58 Democrats crossing party lines to support a bill that hands more power to a tariff-obsessed president certainly was. It seems they wanted to 'punish' Russia more than protect their legislative turf. Some House members were at pains to stress the bill was *not* aimed at India.

That's a distinction without a difference. And it's ultimately irrelevant, because the targets were always top buyers of Russian oil. However, 152 Dems did vote 'No' to try to preserve what remains of Congressional dignity and authority. The final vote was 262-159.

Congressman Gregory Meeks, the senior-most Democrat on the House Foreign Affairs Committee and a strong opponent, called the bill 'deeply flawed'. It hands 'the president sweeping new tariff authorities that he can abuse...'. With such extraordinary powers in hand, it'll be open season on whichever government Trump's angry with at a given time, he added. Ask Canada.

In the end, nothing mattered. Republicans' penchant to please Trump ranked above their constituents' economic travails. Which, by the way, are greatly exacerbated because of the US war on Iran and Trump's inability to end it.

Finally, a threat of further sanctions under the new law is unlikely to scare either Putin to end his war on Ukraine, or Xi Jinping to stop helping Russia and Iran with intelligence and equipment. Besides, Trump will host Xi later this week for a peace-making and content-light summit. He knows better than to threaten the guest with new tariffs after China blocked rare earth minerals to the US last year, forcing 'Tariff King' Trump to quickly backtrack.

India is another story. It doesn't control any critical supply chain it can block to make life impossible for US companies.



She Said She Said The Beatles

'She Said She Said', tucked inside the Beatles' groundbreaking 1966 album, *Revolver*, is yet a track that's catchy and yet, a... 'slightly unwell'. It starts as psychedelic rock, and ends somewhere inside a disturbed memory.

John Lennon's lyrics stem from an LSD-fuelled encounter with actor Peter Fonda, whose repeated talk of knowing 'what it's like to be dead' deeply irritated him. Lennon turned the episode into something darker: a conversation in which death, childhood and the unsettling unreliability of experience bleed into one another. The sudden recollection of childhood

— 'When I was a boy everything was right' — gives the song its emotional kink. Musically, the brilliance lies in making instability groove. Guitars shimmer and snarl. The metre shifts. The bass pushes and pulls. And Ringo Starr is magnificent. Rather than simply planting the backbeat, he *implies* it, circling it with toms, fills and wonderfully restless accents.

As Lennon intones, 'I said, 'Even though you know what you know, / I know that I'm ready to leave, / 'Cause you're making me feel like I've never been born, / we are left listening, and for 2 min 39 sec, evaporating.



THE SPEAKING TREE

Silence Awakens

SANT RAJINDER SINGH

The greatest obstacle separating us from the priceless gift of attaining true fulfillment is the noise pollution that fills our lives. It is present in the constant noise of the outer world: the unending stream of communication and information competing for our attention. Yet, an even greater form of noise pollution, the mind's restless activity — thoughts, desires, worries, ambitions, fears and the continual pull of the senses — obscures life's deeper purpose: to know ourselves, to know God, and to realise our relationship with Creator so we can find our way back Home.

Meditation is the sacred process of withdrawing from the noise and entering the silence in which the soul awakens. As we do so, we begin to experience the divine Light and Sound, the eternal Naam, or holy word, that reverberates through all of creation. In this sacred silence, the soul awakens to itself and to God. It is in silence that the companionship of Creator is experienced, and treasures hidden within the soul begin to reveal themselves.

What first appears to be silence becomes awakening of the soul, and the One whom we have sought throughout the world is finally discovered within. When this happens, bliss naturally unfolds. The physical, emotional and mental benefits of meditation are also experienced in the process, but these are only offshoots of meditation.

Chat Room

Breaking News Is Nothing New

Appropos the Edit, 'Jarasandha Principle And Party Demerger' (Sep 19), the ancient mythology befits the break-up of current Indian political parties. What begins as internal leadership dispute gradually becomes a battle over the party's name, symbol, organisation and legacy. Splits are not an aberration but a recurring feature of India's political evolution. The concern becomes significant when the beneficiaries are aligned with the ruling political establishment. Political movements cannot remain permanently united. But when the division involves control over a party's lifelong assets, the process assumes significance far beyond an internal quarrel. ECI must ensure that dispute adjudication itself does not become a source of controversy. Impartiality must not merely be asserted; it must be visible in every decision.

Gregory Fernandes Mumbai

Token Charge for Tokenised Spend

This refers to 'Splitting UPI Payment? No Daily Cap for Now' by Pranav Mukul and Nikhil Patwardhan (Sep 19). 0.4% MDR for specific merchant payments above ₹2,000 is likely to be passed on to the payer, either by reducing the discount offered or by other means. If the rationale for introducing MDR is to recover the cost of maintaining UPI infrastructure, why should the charge be a percentage of the transaction value?

The UPI process and infrastructure remain the same, whether the transaction is for ₹1 or ₹5,000. Instead, a small fixed charge, say, ₹1 per transaction for payments above ₹2,000, would be really nominal. The issue needs to be reconsidered in public interest.

MS Allama Prabhu Bengaluru

Arm's Line and Length in Sport

Appropos 'BCCI Writing Foreign Policy?' by Anand Vasu (Sep 16), sport and diplomacy often intersect, but institutional sporting decisions should not become substitutes for national foreign policy. BCCI has considerable influence because of cricket's popularity and commercial reach, yet, matters involving international relations require broader governmental and diplomatic consideration. At the same time, sporting bodies should retain operational autonomy within clearly defined rules. India can protect its sporting interests while allowing foreign policy to be handled through established diplomatic channels and national institutions.

AS Nithish Kumar Neelambur, Tamil Nadu

Letters to the editor may be addressed to editet@timesofindia.com

Hope

Greed

Fear

Panic

Hope

Beating Volatility

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MUMBAI, MONDAY, 21 SEPTEMBER 2026

SMART INVESTING

MF SIP Additions at 6-Mth High, Exit Door Busy Too

Sun Life's Kevin Strain on FDI, Bancassurance and More

Sangita Mehta speaks to Sun Life's Kevin Strain on FDI opportunities, misselling, AMCs and AI.

INVESTORS RECALIBRATE

EM Local Bonds Gain Favour as Dollar Debt Lags

Bloomberg

Emerging-market investors are for now sticking with local-currency sovereign debt as surging Treasury yields dim the appeal of dollar-denominated developing-nation bonds. Behind the strategy are attractive valuations and the potential to profit from carry trades, where investors borrow in low-yielding currencies to invest in higher-yielding assets. The preference is showing up in fund flows, positioning and relative performance. A Bloomberg gauge of domestic EM debt has beaten an index of dollar-denominated bonds by more than 3 percentage points since the end of June, set for the biggest quarterly outperformance since 2022. Fund managers are leaning into that divergence too. A Bank of America Corp. survey of 38 global fixed-income fund managers overseeing \$444 billion in combined assets showed that 84% of the respondents were overweight local EM debt relative to hard currency bonds, versus just 38% in August. The poll was conducted between Sept 4 and 9. The trade could still be tested after the Federal Reserve raised interest rates and signaled it may do so again. A renewed advance in the dollar could turn investors away from emerging-market assets such as local-currency debt.

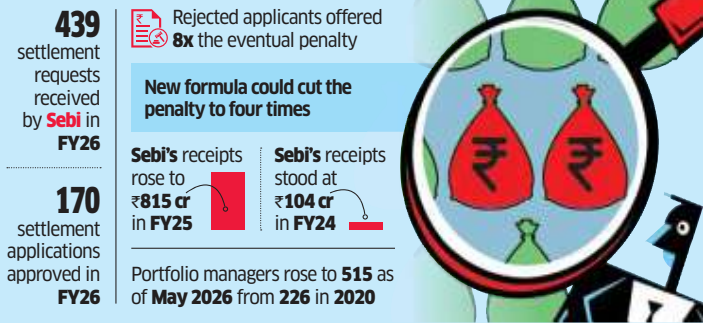
POLICY SHIFT Market regulator may allow resolution if diverted funds are returned with interest

India Inc, Individuals Could Soon Get to Settle Fund Diversion Cases

Reena Zachariah

Mumbai: India's capital market regulator plans to let companies and individuals accused of siphoning funds out of listed companies settle their cases, a route currently closed to them. It also plans to introduce a new mutual fund-only category for portfolio management services (PMS). Sebi's board meets on September 24 and is likely to consider both proposals. Settlement lets an accused party end a case by agreement with the regulator: Sebi has so far refused it in cases involving diversion of funds or misstated financial accounts, because they can hurt large numbers of investors and damage market integrity. Under the proposal, offenders would have to return the diverted money with interest and make appropriate disclosures to investors. Sebi's view is that an offender willing to bring back the diver-

Settlement Reset



ted funds along with interest to the company changes whether such a case can be settled. Pratap Venugopal, senior advocate, at the Supreme Court, said settlement is "not synonymous with leniency". "Cases involving widespread investor

harm or market-integrity concerns, a settlement backed by meaningful restitution, disgorgement and corrective action could serve investors and the market more effectively than prolonged proceedings,". He said the changes marked a shift towards "a more prag-

matic enforcement framework."

In FY2026, Sebi received 439 settlement applications, approved 170, and rejected, withdrew or returned 199. A Sebi study on the settlement applications filed in the past two years showed that settlement amounts proposed and not accepted in such matters were, on average, eight times higher than the penalty amount they eventually paid. Sebi's receipts from settlement and compounding charges rose eightfold to ₹815 crore in FY25 from ₹104 crore in FY24, its annual accounts showed.

Sandeep Parekh, managing partner at Finsec Law Advisors, said the existing pricing left accused parties with no reason to settle: "a rational noticee litigates". The new formula, the notice to settle before a show-cause notice and settlement at the appellate stage should change that calculation meaningfully, he said.

Continued on >>> Smart Investing

active bhi, passive bhi

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THE TWO-YEAR ITCH

Sensex's Longest Wait for a New High Since 2012

Sanket Dhanorkar

Seven hundred and twenty-five days have passed since the BSE Sensex touched its previous high on September 26, 2024. Two years of flattish returns are testing investors' patience.

Since 2012, this is the longest stretch without a new Sensex record high. Yet the Sensex is down only 13.4% from its September 2024 peak, as of 18 September 2026. Unlike a sharp price correction, a time correction erodes returns through stagnation, leaving portfolios stuck for months or years.

History shows that such periods can be prolonged. The 2008 financial crisis saw a 56% fall over one year, followed by a 20-month recovery. Investors who entered near the January 2008 peak saw no return for almost three years. The 1994 correction was even more painful: a 41% fall over 27 months, followed by another 31 months of recovery—adding to five years of no return.

For More Pick Up Today's THE ECONOMIC TIMES

Wealth

The post-2000 tech bubble correction took nearly four years from fall to recovery.

WHY TIME CORRECTIONS HURT

The psychological damage builds slowly. A portfolio may remain marginally underwater, but months without appreciation reduce purchasing power and push financial goals further away. Investors may see portfolio return lagging FDs and feel compelled to chase alternatives.

Continued on >>> Smart Investing

PRIMARY MARKET ACTION TO STAY HOT WITH NEW OFFERS AND LISTINGS

It's IPO Season, 20 More Cos to Hit Street

Combined issue size at around ₹4,152 cr; eleven IPOs opened last week seeking over ₹24,500 cr

Seven mainboard and 13 SME initial public offerings (IPOs) are scheduled to open for subscription between September 21 and 25, extending the momentum in the primary market fundraising. The 20 issues have a combined issue size of around ₹4,152 crore. This follows five mainboard and six SME IPOs that opened for subscription last week, with a combined issue size of around ₹24,563 crore. NSE's ₹22,561-crore IPO—the largest this year—is set to close on Monday. The issue has been fully subscribed. Among the mainboard issues this week, Ele-

vate Campuses' ₹2,100 crore IPO will be the largest. All the other issue sizes are below ₹1,000 crore.

LISTINGS

The week will also see six mainboard and eight SME companies that launched their IPOs last week list on the exchanges.

Among the mainboard companies, Manika Plastech will list on September 21, while SS Retail, Hero Motors and Jindal Supreme India will list on September 23. NSE and Sonaselection India will list on September 24.

Among SME companies, Injecto Polymers and Century Business Media will list on September 21. Vama Wovenfab, Shakti Polytarp and Quanto Agroworld will list on September 22, followed by Spectra Technology Solutions and Kheria Autocomp on September 24 and Axiom Gas Engineering on September 25.

Compiled by Ravindra Sonavane

New on the Block

Mainboard IPOs	Opening	Closing	Price Band (₹)	Issue Size (₹cr)
Varmora Granito	Sep 22	Sep 24	140-148	708
Adroit Industries (India)	Sep 23	Sep 25	126-134	151
Elevate Campuses	Sep 23	Sep 25	343-362	2,100
Swastika Infra	Sep 23	Sep 25	175-185	161
ArMee Infotech	Sep 23	Sep 25	350-375	300
A-One Steels India	Sep 24	Sep 28	385-405	405
Moneyview	Sep 24	Sep 28	NA	NA
SME IPOs				
FX Multitech	Sep 21	Sep 23	110-116	43
Robokidz Eduventures	Sep 21	Sep 23	100-106	29
Pooja Logistics	Sep 23	Sep 25	109-115	42
Liqvd Digital India	Sep 23	Sep 25	51-54	39
Unitec Fibres	Sep 23	Sep 25	83-88	33

Source: ET Data team



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Make Growth Happen

Jane Street Bets Big on Leveraged ETF Swaps

Jane Street Group has begun providing swaps to a swelling cohort of leveraged ETFs, amping up the competition in a niche but lucrative corner of the derivatives market.

The trading giant entered the business earlier this year and furnished about \$1.2 billion notional of swaps in the second quarter to roughly 75 leveraged and inverse single-stock exchange-traded funds listed in the US, according to quarterly filings data compiled by Asym Research.

Focusing on single-stock ETFs, the firm now accounts for approximately 2% for the segment. Clear Street leads the way with about 21%, while Marex Group Ltd holds around 11%.

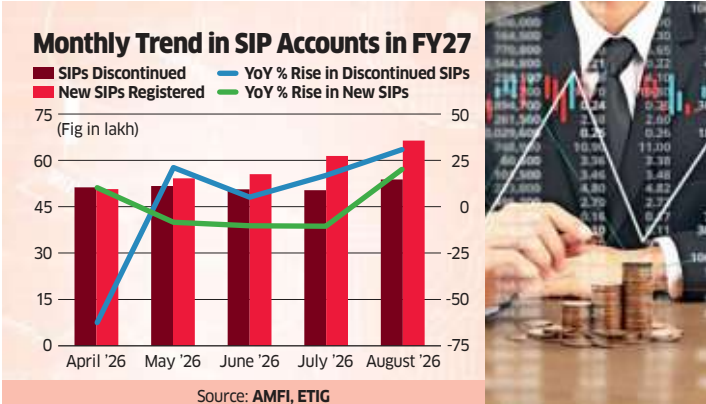
US leveraged ETF assets peaked above \$200 billion in the second quarter, fueled in part by the growth of single-stock products.—Bloomberg

TWO-WAY STREET The number of discontinued SIPs, though lower than fresh additions, rose at a faster rate for the fourth consecutive month in August, indicating volatility

SIP Additions at a Six-Month High, Exit Door is Busy Too

Sachin Kumar

ET Intelligence Group: Even as net additions to systematic investment planning (SIP) accounts touched a six-month high in August, the year-on-year rate of increase remained volatile amid a higher pace of SIP discontinuations. The number of discontinued SIPs, though lower than fresh additions, rose at a faster rate for the fourth consecutive month in August, according to the data from Association of Mutual Funds in India (AMFI). Discontinued SIPs rose 31% year-on-year compared with a 20% increase in new SIP registrations. As many as 53.8 lakh SIPs were either discontinued or matured in August, against 66.4 lakh new SIP registrations. In the first five months of the current fi-



scal, a total of 2.9 crore new SIPs were registered, while 2.6 crore SIPs were discontinued or matured. The growth in contributing SIP

accounts has also moderated, suggesting that rising discontinuations are beginning to offset a part of fresh additions. Contributing

SIP accounts do not include folios that paused investments for the month. After declining marginally by 85,000 in May, contributing SIP accounts increased by 14.2 lakh in June, but the incremental addition fell to 11.9 lakh in July and further to 11.6 lakh in August. Contributing accounts reached 10 crore in August, up from 9.9 crore in July.

Monthly net SIP account additions have increased since May after falling by nearly 58,000 in April. Net additions rose to 12.6 lakh in August from 11.1 lakh in July, 4.9 lakh in June and 2.5 lakh in May.

Net SIP inflow rose 21% year-on-year to ₹32,297 crore in August. SIP inflow has remained in the ₹31,000-32,000 crore range in FY27 so far. Total SIP inflow reached ₹1.6 lakh crore during April-August, implying a year-on-year increase of 15%.

TECHNICAL VIEWS

Nifty Near 23,000 Floor, but It Is Not All Clear Yet

The Nifty extended its losing streak to a sixth consecutive week, testing the key 23,100-23,000 support zone. While recent recovery indicates demand at lower levels, the broader trend remains under pressure.

CHANDAN TAPARIA
HEAD - DERIVATIVES & TECHNICALS, WEALTH MANAGEMENT,
MOTILAL OSWAL FINANCIAL SERVICES

Trading Strategy: Nifty held above 23,000-23,100 support, forming a base near 23,100-23,200. Daily candles show buying, but weekly charts remain weak with lower highs and lows.

For the weekly September 22 expiry, the recommended Nifty options strategy is a Bear Put Spread: buy one lot of the 23,400 Put and sell one lot of the 23,200 Put. The maximum risk is 70 points (₹4,550), while the maximum potential profit is 130 points (₹8,450) per lot.

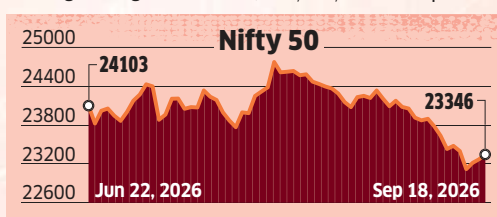
TOP BETS FOR THE WEEK
SONACOM: Buy | **CMP: ₹808 | Target: ₹850 |**

SOMIL MEHTA
HEAD RETAIL RESEARCH,
MIRAE ASSET SHAREKHAN

Trading Strategies
Nifty: The index's slide from 24,774 to 23,116 keeps the medium-term trend bearish below key averages, though 23,050-23,100 offers firm support with rebound potential towards 23,750-23,950. Buy Nifty at CMP with a

Stop loss: ₹785
The stock has respected its 50-day DEMA, rebounded with a strong bullish candle after a healthy correction, and shows renewed buying interest with an RSI crossover and expanding volumes.

AURO PHARMA: Buy | **CMP: ₹1,734 | Target: ₹1,840 | Stop loss: ₹1,680**
The stock remains in a strong uptrend near all-time highs, forming a bullish Marubozu candle and making higher highs; the breakout above ₹1,717 confirms strength, supported by rising moving averages.



HITESH RATHI
TECHNICAL ANALYST - EQUITY & DERIVATIVES,
ANGEL ONE

Trading Strategy: The recovery in Nifty and the broader market following a Bullish Harami pattern indicates demand at lower levels. However, the breakdown below 23,600 has turned the broader trend bearish, with no meaningful signs of reversal yet. The recent three-day rise offers scope to initiate short positions on retracement. Nifty can be sold on rallies towards 23,450-23,500, with a stop loss

at 23,580 and targets of 23,300-23,200.

TOP BETS FOR THE WEEK
Tilaknagar Industries:

Buy | **CMP: ₹570 | Target: ₹645-650 | Stop loss: ₹495**

The stock broke out across timeframes on strong volumes and retested the zone on low supply, keeping the breakout healthy; Point & Figure charts have invalidated a prior bearish setup, confirming buyers' control.

PhysicsWallah: Buy | **CMP: ₹136 | Target: ₹155-158 | Stop loss: ₹125**
The stock has taken support at an upward-sloping trendline, triggering a bullish candlestick breakout, with Double Top and Swing breakouts on Point & Figure and Renko charts confirming the uptrend.

potential for a fresh leg higher.

NHPC: Buy | **CMP: ₹76.50 | Target: ₹81-83 | Stop loss: ₹74**
After a multi-month triangle correction, a five-wave rise, Friday's sharp surge, and a bullish daily momentum crossover signal the phase may be over, supporting further upside.

Corporates Crowd Bond Street Amid Interest Rate-Hike Buzz

Several large issues have gone through, with more likely next week

Rozebud Gonsalves

Mumbai: Indian companies are taking advantage of the prevailing surplus liquidity conditions and are continuing to tap the bond market despite higher yields and an uncertain rate outlook, corporate bond experts said.

Several large issuers raised funds in recent days and more are expected to come to the market next week, ahead of a potential rate hike and expectations of tighter liquidity conditions. The six-member Monetary Policy Committee will meet October 5-7 amid expectation of a quarter-percentage-point hike in the policy rate to 5.50%.

Indian companies are expected to raise more than ₹1,000 crore this week, with Edelweiss Financial Services the first to hit the market with a ₹300 crore non-con-

vertible debenture issue on Monday. Bajaj Auto Credit and India-First Life Insurance Company are likely to raise ₹250 crore and ₹200 crore, respectively.

Vedanta's board approved a ₹3,500 crore bond issuance, while state-owned Power Grid Corporation's board cleared a ₹5,000 crore bond proposal, according to BSE filings.

"I do not expect the corporate bond market to slow materially despite the incredible probability of higher interest rates. In fact, there is a visible change in the issuer behaviour. Several large issuers have been active and they are increasingly looking to lock in funding before system liquidity drains out and borrowing costs move higher," said Venkatakrishnan Srinivasan, managing partner at Rockfort

Fincap, a debt advisory firm.

Banking system liquidity has stood at a large surplus this month because of inflows from the FCNR (B) deposits that banks raised under a central bank programme. The daily average surplus was ₹9.97 lakh crore, compared with ₹3.67 lakh crore in August and ₹1.07 in July, RBI data showed. The sharp increase in surplus liquidity has left banks looking for avenues to deploy these funds, and corporate bond issuances are emerging as one such avenue, experts said.

Reliance Industries raised ₹2,500 crore through five-year bonds last week, while Bajaj Finance and Tata Capital recently tapped the market with three-year issuances. The three- to five-year segment is seeing strong demand, as banks have surplus funds from the FCNR (B) deposits, which have largely come in with a similar maturity profile.

Settling Fund Diversion Cases

►► From ET Markets Page 1

But a fourfold premium still hit hardest those with a strong defence. Sebi has also proposed allowing a rejected settlement applicant to make a fresh application at a later stage if circumstances change at an extra 20% of the settlement amount.

PORTFOLIO MANAGERS

The board is also likely to discuss an overhaul of portfolio management services (PMS), private and professionally run investment accounts for wealthier investors. Assets have more than doubled since April 2019, to ₹42.61 lakh crores as of May 2026. The number of portfolio managers has also doubled, to 515

from 226 in 2020. Clients rose by almost half, to 2.19 lakh, Sebi data showed. Sebi proposed a new category, MF-PMS, in which managers would invest in direct mutual fund schemes, exchange-traded funds and specialised investment funds. The minimum investment would fall to ₹25 lakh from ₹50 lakh.

Portfolio managers would also be allowed to buy overseas listed equities, debt, mutual funds and REITs. Derivatives exposure would be capped at 1.25 times a client's assets.

Pankaj Murarka, CIO at Renaissance Investment Managers, called the changes "very progressive", in sync with clients' needs and changing investment landscape and said these would accelerate industry growth.

Sensex's Longest Wait for a New High Since 2012

►► From ET Markets Page 1

"Your portfolio value may not go down, but you don't see any material appreciation even after several months of patient contributions," says Deepak Chhabria, CEO, Axiom Financial Services.

A DIFFERENT CORRECTION

Unlike past crises triggered by banking or balance-sheet stress, the current phase is more a valuation-and-time correction, says Ankur Punj, MD of Equirus Wealth.

Strong domestic financialisation and recurring SIP flows have provided a liquidity cushion. Meanwhile, small- and mid-caps have held up better than large-caps, helped by mutual fund and

WE HAVE A PLAN IN PLACE, SAYS INDIA MD BATRA

'FCNR Haul to Power HSBC's India Wealth, Retail Banking Push'

Joel Rebello

Mumbai: British lender HSBC expects the foreign currency non-resident (FCNR) deposits it mobilised under the Reserve Bank of India's special swap facility to act as a force multiplier for its wealth management and retail banking businesses in India.

The inflows, which at \$14.5 billion were second only to the \$17.88 billion that ICICI Bank mobilised under the special FCNR (Bank) facility, give new resources to lend and expand the wealth management business, said Sandeep Batra, its managing director and head of wealth and personal banking in India.

The leverage option of up to 19 times — depositors could borrow 19 times the money they deposited — that the bank offered helped attract depositors, Batra told ET in an interview. Half the deposits were for five years.

"We have a plan in place, and we are doubling down on whatever capability we need to develop," Batra said. "FCNR (B) is one catchment...we are also opening 12 more branches."

Banks combined mobilised \$127.22 billion through FCNR (B) deposits in less than three months until the central bank-driven dollar mop-up exercise closed on August 31, the RBI said earlier this month. HSBC offered deposits ranging from \$100,000 to \$2.5 million, with a leverage up to 19 times, mostly financed through its branch in Gift City, Gujarat. Out of the \$52.8 billion loaned through the Gift City international financial services centre, HSBC accounted for \$10.9 billion.

Globally, the Middle East was the top contributor to the bank's FCNR (B) scheme, followed by Singapore and Hong Kong. Deposits came from more than 30 markets, Batra said. "We were fully prepared from an NRI reach perspective, number of relationship managers, our focus on the global Indian with, of course, the size and scale of our brand," he said.

The fact that the bank has an ongoing six-year-old operation in Gift City gave it an advantage, he said. "We already have clients in thousands in Gift (City). We will pay out interest every six months, which our clients can invest in a range of funds. Clients can make fresh deposits or use our multiple forex cards to spend money," Batra said. "We also have a 7.5%, three-year fixed mortgage, which is attractive in a rising rate scenario."



BROAD REACH

We were prepared from an NRI reach perspective, number of relationship managers, our focus on the global Indian with the size and scale of our brand

SANDEEP BATRA

Managing Director and Head of Wealth and Personal Banking, HSBC India

HSBC offered a flat 5.5% interest on three- to five-year deposits. The lending rate was 5% to 5.15%, or 35-50 basis points below the deposit rate. How much clients could borrow depended on their credit profile. After taking into account the leverage, the delivered yield for clients was 10-14%.

Batra said one-third of the clients onboarded during the 52-day RBI window were credit appraised, which would be a force multiplier for the bank's wealth management business across the board.

In wealth management, HSBC offers services to clients starting with ₹50 lakh of assets to up to \$2 million (₹80 crore) for private banking clients. With a retail broking business now likely to be started later this year, the bank has a full suite of products to offer to its wealthy clients, Batra said.

The bank plans to use the liquidity generated through the FCNR scheme conservatively, he said. "We are finding deployment tools; those deployment tools should be corporate lending, which is match funded, and mortgages like the three-year fixed product, which we launched recently. Some of it could be deployed into government securities. So, it will be a combination."

Policy Doctor: Health Insurance Guide



SHILPA ARORA
COO, INSURANCE SAMADHAN

We are covered under a group health insurance policy from a leading standalone insurer since March 2024. Prior to purchasing the policy (as customers of our bank), my wife underwent a medical check-up that confirmed she had no major pre-existing diseases. However, she was subsequently diagnosed with carcinoma of the left breast and was operated upon in May. Initially, both her cashless claim and subsequent chemotherapy claims were rejected. I approached the Insurance Ombudsman, who passed a favourable order in our case.

Following this order, some claims were settled, but the insurer has rejected the claims for the last six chemotherapy cycles as well as radiation sessions. The reason provided for this rejection is that the maximum permissible amount has already been given. However, our policy has a sum assured of ₹25 lakhs, and the rejected claim amount is not even ₹2.5 lakh. Given these circumstances, I would appreciate your advice on the best course of action. Do I need to file a fresh complaint with the Insurance Ombudsman re-

garding these specific rejected claims, or should this be escalated as a case of non-compliance with the previous order?

-Hitiendra Gilituola, Mumbai
You should approach the existing Insurance Ombudsman office to report non-compliance and seek enforcement of the previous favourable order, rather than filing an entirely fresh complaint.

Write a formal application to the same Insurance Ombudsman office that had issued the favourable order. State that the insurer has partially complied but is wrongfully withholding payments for subsequent ongoing treatment (chemotherapy and radiation) under arbitrary sub-limits or caps not aligned with your ₹25 lakh sum assured.

You may also carefully re-examine the master policy wording obtained through the bank. Group policies sometimes carry hidden disease-specific or procedure-specific caps (such as per-cycle limits for chemotherapy). If no such explicit clause exists in your specific certificate of insurance, highlight this discrepancy in your non-compliance filing.

Have a health insurance query? Write to us at etwealth@timesofindia.com

For a First, NaBFID Plans to Raise \$1.5 b via Overseas Bonds

Shilpy Sinha

Mumbai: National Bank for Financing Infrastructure and Development (NaBFID) is looking to raise \$500 million through a 10-year bond, marking its debut in the overseas bond market, while separately holding talks with the Multilateral Investment Guarantee Agency (MIGA) to raise around \$1 billion through a 15-year bond, people familiar with the development said.

The 15-year bond, which is expected to carry a MIGA guarantee, will help the development finance institution access longer-term overseas funding, a key requirement for a lender financing long-gestation infrastructure projects.

"We are in the market to raise an indicative amount of \$500 million, with a tenor of 10 years," a company executive said.

NaBFID is targeting around \$4 billion in dollar funding by December through a mix of loans and bonds, including the current \$500 million bond and external commercial borrowings.

The institution is tapping the Reserve Bank of India's concessional US dollar-rupee swap facility, which was operationalised in June to lower hedging costs for eligible overseas borrowings. The facility provides a concessional swap cost of 1.5% a year for eligible external commercial borro-

wings and overseas foreign currency borrowings, with drawdowns permitted until December 31.

The cost advantage of overseas borrowing, however, has narrowed as US Treasury yields have risen. After factoring in the 1.5% swap cost, dollar borrowing costs are now closer to domestic bond market rates.

"About two months back the savings were quite substantial. Now it has almost come to the domestic bond market rates. It is slightly cheaper," the executive said.

The infra financier is targeting around \$4 b in dollar funding by December through a mix of loans and bonds
Bank of Maharashtra recently raised \$500 million through a five-year US dollar bond at 130 basis points over US Treasury yields, with a 6.12% coupon. Including the 1.5% swap cost, the effective cost would be around 7.6%, broadly in line with current domestic borrowing costs for comparable institutions.

The cost of NaBFID's 10-year bond will depend on the prevailing US Treasury yield and the spread at which the issue is priced.

The proposed MIGA-backed borrowing will be a separate 15-year tranche of around \$1 billion. "That will be a 15-year tranche. And that will be almost a billion dollar," the executive said.

Indian HNIs Sitting on SpaceX Windfall Have Some Questions

Investors in unlisted shares via funds face compliance issues post in-specie transfers

Sugata Ghosh

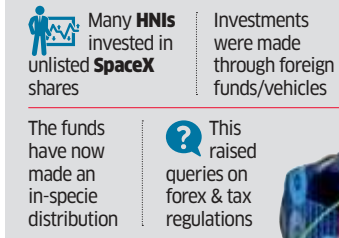
Mumbai: Many Indians holding millions of dollars in SpaceX shares are grappling with questions about preserving their fortune.

Well before the company's initial public offering in June, they bought unlisted shares through specially created offshore funds and vehicles, as there was no way to tap SpaceX to acquire tiny stock parcels.

They subscribed to unlisted fund units under the liberalised remittance scheme (LRS) that allows a resident individual to spend and invest up to \$250,000 a year overseas, subject to conditions that have become more complex.

Following recent developments, these investors are seeking legal advice to check if the timing of investment, nature of fund, and securities they hold comply with complex forex regulations. This has been triggered by fund managers making in-specie distribution of SpaceX shares to investors. Instead of giving cash after selling stocks, funds extinguished units and transferred

Compliance Check



SpaceX shares to investors' overseas demat accounts.

Why did they do this? To avoid stock dumping, particularly with the scrip down to \$154 from its peak of \$225, and to defer tax for investors. Some funds wound up with investors wanting to either hold the stock directly or cash out.

But can receipt of shares throw a regulatory hurdle? "One may question whether in-specie distribution requires prior RBI approval. It should not where an Indian investor had no legal or operational control over either distribution or liquidation. In such circumstances, receipt of listed shares should not be viewed as a regulatory violation," said Vishal Gada, founder and CEO of Aurtus, a firm specialising in tax, regulatory and transactions.

Under LRS, swapping one asset with another (units to shares) is allowed in M&As or liquidation. But

will it be construed as genuine liquidation when a fund set up to hold a stock is dismantled soon after listing?

According to Harshal Bhuta, partner at CA firm P.R. Bhuta & Co., "Under LRS, reinvestment rule sale proceeds can't be left idle beyond six months. Though in-specie distribution may qualify as capital gains depending on fund structure, there's no forex realisation. So, there's no obligation to liquidate SpaceX shares received in exchange for units to meet the reinvestment rule."

However, the mode of reinvestment should be evaluated on a case-to-case basis, said Moin Ladha, partner, Khaitan & Co. This would depend on a fund's terms and how it has been implemented, he said.

WHEN, HOW?

What's also crucial is when and how the investment happened. Those

Hiring Expands Beyond Metros as Smaller Cities Gain Ground: Report

Mumbai: Small cities are emerging as major talent hubs, with a majority of employers witnessing a significant increase in hiring from tier II and III locations in the last two years, according to a report.

India's hiring landscape is increasingly moving beyond traditional metropolitan centres, as 69% of organisations reported increasing hiring from tier II and III cities by more than 30% over the last two years, said

the report by workforce staffing and HR solutions firm Genius HRTech. The report is based on



inputs from 1,729 employers via a survey in August across sectors, including finance and BFSI, FMCG, engineering, information technology, manufacturing, telecom, and retail and e-commerce amongst others.—PTI

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE (Mechanical Department)

E-tender No. SPJW-26-BVCM100-FITTING
The Chief Workshop Manager, E. C. Railway, Samastipur for and on behalf of the President of India invites Open tender from experienced and financially capable tenderers for the following works in E-tendering mode of IREPS web portal of Indian Railways:
1. Name of work: Supply, transportation, handling, installation/fitment work for BVCW wagon for the work of Interior fitting, Electrical including Solar Work at Mechanical Workshop, E. C. Railway, Samastipur. **2. Approx. Cost of the work:** Rs. 5,54,51,452.00. **3. Earnest Money to be deposited:** Rs. 11,09,200.00. **4. Date and Time of Tender Closing:** 07/10/2026 15:00 Hrs. **5. Website Particulars, where complete details can be seen etc:** www.ireps.gov.in
Chief Workshop Manager, E. C. Railway, Samastipur
PR/0936/LOCO SHED SAMASTIPUR/MECH/T/26-27/28

NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY

E-Open Tender

Dy.CME/Works for Chief Workshop Manager, N. E. Railway, Mechanical Workshop, Gorakhpur for and on behalf of President of India invites tender through Online E-Open Tender for the following work -
S.No. 1. E-Tender Notice No & Name of the work : Tender No. -"23-GKP-MWS-2026-27" "Modification work in LHB First AC Coaches, Qty. 55 Nos, as per RCF CAI at Mechanical workshop Gorakhpur, Coaching Depot LJN and BSB". Estimated cost (in Rs.): 11422400.00, Earnest Money (in Rs.): 228500.00, Last date of tender submission - Upto 11:00, Date : 12.10.2026, Cost of the Tender forms - ₹ Zero, Period of Contract : 12 Months.
The details of above tender are also available on Indian Railway website "https://www.ireps.gov.in"

Dy. CME/Works, Mechanical Workshop, Gorakhpur, CPRO/Mech. - 87
"Never travel on roof and foot boards"

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-tender No. 40 of 2026-27 (Open)-Engg/DDU
On line (through e-tendering) for the following work is invited by DRM/Engg/DDU for and on behalf of the President of India from experienced and financially as well as technically sound contractors including those enlisted with the Railway, CPWD, BSNL, MES, PWD and other public sector undertakings:- **Tender No. 20-DDU-SR DEN-16-26-27** **Name of work with its location:** Special repair of staff quarters by leaky roof repair, drain, septic tank, etc at way side station in GC-I under SR. DEN/I/DDU. **Advised Value:** Rs.13587855.85 **Earnest Money:** Rs. 271,800.00
Tender No. 21-DDU-SR DEN-I-26-27 **Name of work with its location:** Supply of welding portion and other consumable materials for SSE(PWay)/CDMR,BBU and XBKJ under SR. DEN/I/DDU. **Advised Value:** Rs.6805416.24 **Earnest Money:** Rs.136100.00
Closing Date & time for submission of e-tender: 08.10.2026, Up-to 12:00 hrs.
Website particulars of e-tendering: www.ireps.gov.in
Divisional Railway Manager/ East Central Railway Pt. Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Division
PR/0938/DDU/ENG/G/7/26-27/40

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

Electrical (G)/Department

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE
NO. 1-Open-26-27-15, Dt 16-09-2026
The Divl. Rly Manager (Elect/G)/Sonpur for and behalf of the president of India invites "Open E-Tender" for following works. The last date of online E-Tendering is **08.10.2026 upto 12:30 Hrs.** All information and tender documents related to E-tender is available on website - www.ireps.gov.in
Sr.No.: 1. Name of Work: AT BJU:- Provision of 750 V Power Supply for HOG testing at Newly washing pit at Coaching Depo BJU, **Approx Cost (In Rs.): 1,14,52,997.00, Earnest Money (In Rs.): 2,29,100.00, Cost of Tender document (in Rs.): 00.00 (Non-refundable): 00.00**
The above Tender notice is available on website-www.ireps.gov.in RIGHT OF RAILWAY TO DEAL WITH TENDER. Railway Administration reserves the right to postpone /modify or to cancel the tenders without assigning any reason.
Sr. Divl. Elect. Engineer / (Elect/G) East Central Railway/Sonpur
PR/0946/SEE/ELECT/T/26-27/36

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE

No. DNR/S&T/Sig/2026/18 Danapur, Dtd. 15.09.2026. Divisional Railway Manager (Signal & Telecom), East Central Railway, Danapur Division, for and on behalf of President of India invites tenders on web portal www.ireps.gov.in for the following work.
1. Name of work with its location: S&T works (Indoor & Outdoor) with new EI in connection with Yard remodelling at Jehanabad Station having provision of Up loop line No-1 and DN loop line No-4 to be converted as common loop along with shunt signal in DN main line for all lines along with extension of goods line no-2 upto 50 metre towards PNB and at JHD station in Patna Gaya section under Danapur Division." **2. Approximate cost of work:** ₹95613590.36, **3. Bid Security:** ₹1912300.00, **4. Last Date & Time of Submission:** Up to 15:00 hrs. on 07.10.2026, **5. Opening of tender:** 15:30 hrs. on 07.10.2026, **6. Website particulars** where detail of the work and criteria can be seen : www.ireps.gov.in, **7. Address of the office** from where detail information can be obtained : Sr. Divnl. Signal & Telecommunication Engineer, East Central Railway, Danapur.
Note: Any corrigendum if required will be uploaded on above website before 14 days.
DSTE/ECR/Danapur
PR/0926/DNR/S&T/T/26-27/44

CENTRAL RAILWAY

BHUSAWAL DIVISION

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDERS

E-TENDER NOTICE NO. BSL/AC/L/

Tender/5626436

RLYMM(AC/L)/BHUSAWAL/CENTRAL RLY, acting for and on behalf of The President of India invites E-Tenders against Tender No 5626436 Closing Date/Time 16-OCT-2026 at 11.30 Hrs. Bidders will be able to submit their original/revised bids up to closing date and time only. Manual offers are not allowed against this tender and any such manual offer received shall be ignored.
1) NIT HEADER Tender No.: 5626436
Tender Type: Adv. Open Tender
Bidding System: Single Window System
Inspection Agency: TPI
Publishing Date/Time: 17/09/26
13:38:09 Estimated Value: 4,21,65,494.6/- **Closing Date:** 16-OCT-2026 11:30 hrs. **Validity of Offer:** 90 Days
Quantity: 49 Nos. **2) ITEM DESCRIPTION :-** Gear Box Case Machined complete for WAP-5 Locomotive as per CLW Drg No. 1210-01-113-004 Alt-2 or Latest. (This item is reserved for CLW approved sources only) **3)** All detail particular of above Tender are available on website: <http://www.ireps.gov.in>
TRAVEL SAFELY, AVOID FOOTBOARD TRAVELLING

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

No. ECR-HQ/Mech(PLG)/0003/2026
Dated: 15.09.2026 For and on behalf of the President of India, E-tender are invited from Firms/ Agencies/ Contractors of reputed having technical expertise and financial solvency for the following works: - **E-tender Notice No: HQMech-26-WL-RGD-ARA-01**
1. Name of Work with its location and completion period: Supply, Installation and Commissioning of 01 CNC Under Floor Wheel Lathe at Coaching Depot/RGD and 01 CNC Portal Wheel Lathe at Coaching Depot/ARA on turnkey basis. Completion Period: 36 months **2. Approx. Cost of work:** Rs. 22,17,85,171.48 (Rupees Twenty Two Crore Seventeen Lakh Eighty Five Thousand One Hundred Seventy One and paise Forty Eight) **3. Earnest Money to be deposited:** Rs. 44,35,700.00 (Rupees Forty Four Lakh Thirty Five Thousand Seven Hundred Only) **4. Date & time of closing of e-tender Date & time of opening of e-tender:** 17:00 hrs. on 06.10.2026 17:30 hrs. on 06.10.2026 **5. Website Particulars:** <https://www.ireps.gov.in/> No manual tender will be accepted against e-tendering.
Dy. CME/Frt./East Central Railway
PR/0934/HQ/MECH/T/26-27/36

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

The Senior Divisional Electrical Engineer (G) East Central Railway, Samastipur for and on behalf of the President of Union of India invites Tender from competent and experienced Contractors having valid Electrical Contractors' license, technical expertise, financial solvency through E-Tendering mode of IREPS web portal of Indian Railway for execution of the following works :-
Tender No. & Date: EL-G-SPJ-26-ET-26-27-RT, Dt-17.09.2026, **Sl. No. 1. Name of Work with its Location:** Augmentation of power supply system including cabling over Samastipur division. **Advised Value :** Rs. 1,36,05,786.77/- (Rupees one crore thirty six lakh five thousand seven hundred eighty six and seventy seven Paise only).
3. Earnest Money/Bid Security: Rs. 2,72,100/- **Cost of tender document-0 (Nil).** **4. Validity of Offer (Days):** 90 days.
5. Date & Time for Closing & Opening of Tender: Date of Closing of E-Tender at 12:00 hours on 09.10.2026, Date of Opening of E-Tender from 12:30 hours on 09.10.2026, **6. Website particulars, Notice board location where complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office:** www.ireps.gov.in. D.R.M.(Elect.) Office/Samastipur
Note: Any other modification/information related to the above said tender will be uploaded on the Website instead of publish in newspaper.
Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer (G) E.C.Railway/Samastipur
PR/0948/SPJ/ELECT/T/26-27/48

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Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer (G) E.C.Railway/Samastipur
PR/0948/SPJ/ELECT/T/26-27/48

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

The Senior Divisional Electrical Engineer (G) East Central Railway, Samastipur for and on behalf of the President of Union of India invites Tender from competent and experienced Contractors having valid Electrical Contractors' license, technical expertise, financial solvency through E-Tendering mode of IREPS web portal of Indian Railway for execution of the following works :-
Tender No. & Date

DECODING GDP GROWTH THE GOOD, THE BAD & THE DATA

The announcement of a stellar showing by the Indian economy in the first quarter, with growth coming in at 7.8%, sparked intense debate. While many said this had been borne out by upbeat, high-frequency proxy datasets, others said the gains were not being felt on the ground. **ET** speaks with economists and looks at the trajectory of a wide range of macroeconomic indicators to decode the puzzle: how well is the economy doing, really?

GDP More Than Aggregation of High-frequency Indicators



PRONAB SEN
INDIA'S FIRST CHIEF STATISTICIAN

We don't feel the GDP growth on the ground because the statistics ministry's estimates come in a long series. We start with the first estimate (e.g. 7.8% for Q1, released on August 31) and then these estimates are revised multiple times as more data comes in. You get the final estimates only after two years. Therefore, people get confused. What this means is that 7.8% is not the final number.

The GDP estimates are a lot more than just the aggregation of the high-frequency data. They bring in all sorts of other things and in certain cases, that data set has been improved a lot. For instance, we have the Periodic Labour Force Survey for quite some time as an input to the GDP estimation process. The new one on the block is the Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises (ASUSE), also conducted by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation. It is not high-frequency because it is an annual report, but it gives you a realistic measure of what is happening in the unorganised sector. This is a dataset that really needs to be tracked because in the corporate sector for which we get data regularly, things are much more stable. ASUSE data is more expansive than the corporate bit.



The first GDP estimate isn't the final one—it gets revised for two years after release. What this means is that 7.8% is not the final number

On the consumption side, we usually don't have an independent measure of this indicator. If you are really looking at something like the cost of living, you still need to look at the consumer price index (CPI). If you are looking at the cost of production, you would look at the wholesale price index (WPI). If you're looking at how much the producers are getting, then you will look at the producer price index (PPI). One can do combinations of these to infer other things as well. The high-frequency indicators have not changed much.

(As told to Kirtika Suneja)

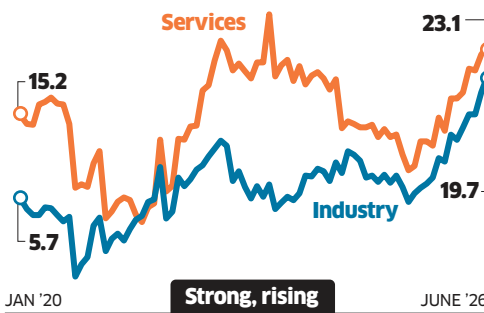
HOW WE CHOSE THE INDICATORS:

The Indian economy has many moving parts, and indicators that track them come in myriad forms. ET drew up a longlist of more than five dozen indicators across all key themes of the economy—from the external sector and markets to farm health and jobs. We then applied one filter to each to narrow it down: does an indicator say something that others don't already say? Where a single number masks more than it reveals, we went a level deeper, e.g., we favoured some sub-indices over well-known indices. Each segment had to tell a complete story—consumption, for example, was paired with credit to flag if spending is debt-led. No such curation can ever be perfect, but the final list has 20 indicators across five segments. The choice of timeframe for each chart was dictated by indicator-specific needs and limitations in data availability and comparability.

INDUSTRY AND BUSINESS ACTIVITY

Business Credit Growth (%)

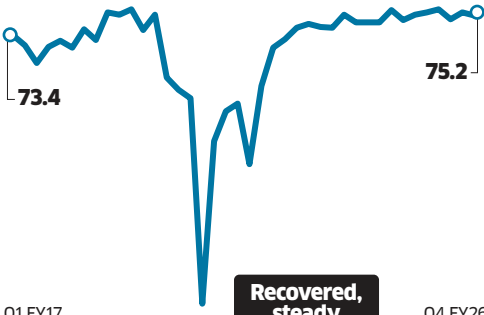
WHY: Shows credit appetite for expansion



Data for banks' outstanding credit; excludes impact of HDFC merger; Source: RBI

Capacity Utilisation in Mfg Sector (%)

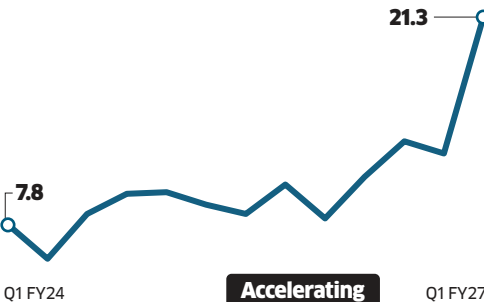
WHY: Shows appetite to invest



Seasonally adjusted Source: RBI

Net Sales Growth of Listed Firms (%)

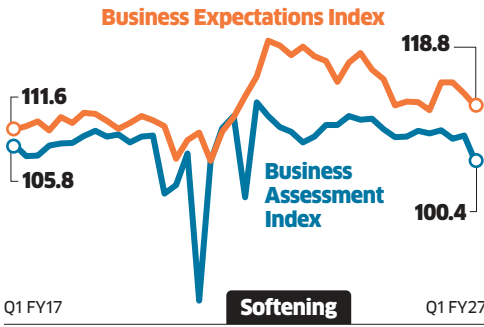
WHY: A barometer of business health



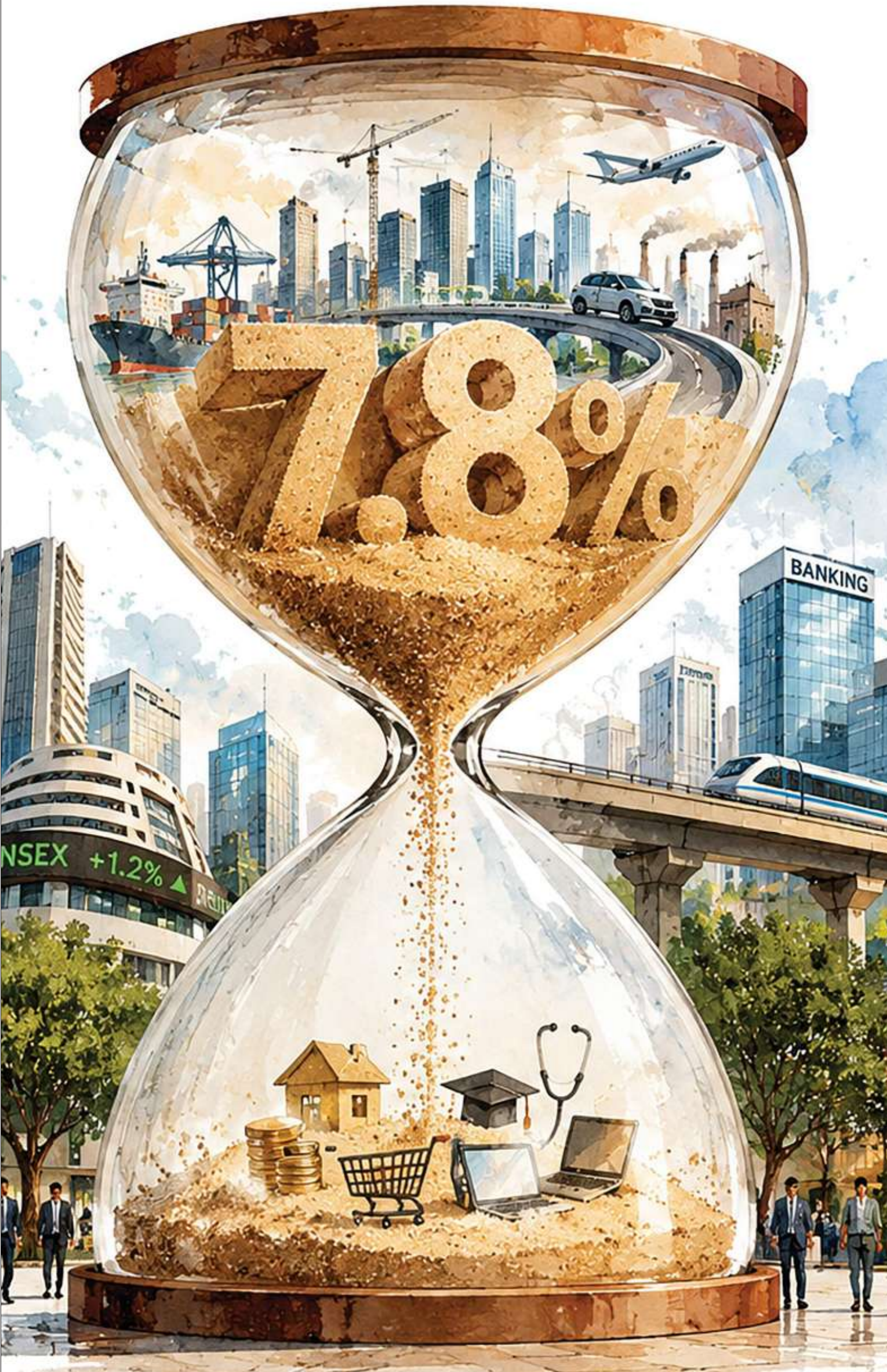
Source: Capitaline, ET Data Team

RBI's Business Sentiment Indices

WHY: A perception check



Pessimism: <100; Optimism: >100 Source: RBI survey



‘Mfg a Bright Spot; Services Presents a Mixed Bag’



UPASNA BHARDWAJ
CHIEF ECONOMIST,
KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK

India's economy has demonstrated notable resilience in 2026, navigating a challenging backdrop of geopolitical tensions, supply chain disruptions, elevated energy prices, weather-related uncertainties and rising input costs.

Despite the ongoing debate around the new GDP series, real GDP growth remained robust at 7.8% in the first quarter, highlighting the economy's ability to absorb external shocks. Importantly, the government has cushioned much of the impact of the West Asia war-led energy shock through excise duty reductions and higher LPG and fertiliser subsidies, limiting the transmission of higher energy costs to households. As a result, domestic demand has remained relatively



insulated, while corporate India has continued to post healthy revenue growth. That said, rising raw material and input costs have weighed on profit margins, tempering earnings growth despite strong topline performance. India's oil intensity (measured by oil consumption in grams per unit of real GDP) has been on a decline—falling from 1.34 in the early 2000s, to 1 in FY16, to 0.74 in FY26. This has also strengthened the economy's ability to withstand energy price shocks.

Investment activity and exports emerged as the primary drivers of growth in the first quarter, although momentum across sectors has remained uneven. High-frequency indicators broadly validate these trends. Manufacturing has been a key bright

spot, supported by strong industrial credit growth, robust electricity demand and sustained expansion in capital goods production, signalling healthy investment momentum. Continued strength in home loan growth, alongside healthy steel and cement consumption, points to ongoing infrastructure focus and real estate activity. Nevertheless, the moderation in fuel consumption and railway freight traffic suggests that pockets of industrial demand have softened.

The services sector, which remains a critical pillar of growth, presents a more mixed picture. While credit growth to the sector remains strong, business sentiment indicators have moderated in recent months. Travel-related activity has also seen some softness, partly reflecting

Corporate India posted strong topline growth in Q1, but rising input costs are squeezing margins... Investment activity, exports emerged as primary drivers of growth in Q1

higher airfares amid elevated aviation fuel costs.

Meanwhile, domestic consumption continues to provide an important anchor for growth. Private consumption remained healthy in Q1, reflected in strong sales growth across passenger vehicles, two-wheelers and tractors. Labour market conditions have also improved, particularly in rural areas, lending further support to household spending.

Looking ahead, strong domestic demand, healthy credit growth, rising investment activity and a resilient corporate sector should continue to support growth in the near term. However, risks to the outlook have increased. Geopolitical uncertainties have persisted, keeping energy and commodity prices vulnerable to renewed volatility at a time when fiscal space to absorb additional shocks is becoming more constrained. Moreover, both global and domestic financial conditions have begun to tighten as monetary policy enters a hiking phase.

The fading benefits of earlier GST-related tax reductions, gradual pass-through of higher input costs and less favourable base effects are also likely to moderate growth momentum over the coming quarters.

‘Govt Support, Benign Inflation Helped in Q1’



SONAL VARMA
CHIEF ECONOMIST, INDIA & ASIA
(EXCL. JAPAN), NOMURA

India's growth has remained remarkably resilient, with domestic demand—particularly consumption—providing an important anchor. Despite geopolitical disruptions and higher crude oil prices, activity has held up well. A key support has been the relatively limited pass-through of higher global energy prices to retail fuel prices, alongside still-benign underlying inflation, which has protected household purchasing power. At the same time, government supply-side management and continued public capital expenditure have supported broader activity. These factors have translated into strong consumption

momentum so far in FY27.

However, we expect growth momentum to moderate as we move into the second half of the fiscal year. First, firms have so far absorbed part of the rise in input costs through lower margins. Some delayed pass-through to consumers could eventually weigh on real purchasing power. Higher food prices will also squeeze real disposable incomes. Second, deficient rainfall and weaker kharif sowing pose risks to agricultural incomes and, consequently, rural consumption demand. Third, some consolidation in government expenditure in H2FY27, particularly capex, could reduce an important support to activity.

We therefore expect GDP growth to moderate from around 7.3% in H1FY27 to 6.7% in H2, still delivering a solid 7% for FY27 overall.



Oil Prices Key External Risk, But Yet to Derail Growth Outlook



RADHIKA RAO
EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR & SENIOR
ECONOMIST, DBS BANK

Recent high-frequency indicators show growth is holding up despite a less supportive global backdrop, as credit growth maintains a strong beat, government expenditure remains apace and production measures are off highs but still in expansionary territory.

Rising oil prices and disruptions to energy transit routes have emerged as key external risks, though they have yet to materially derail the growth outlook, helped by India's diversified crude sourcing strategy and ability to secure alternative supplies. Factoring in to some extent the spillover from higher

input costs and heightened global uncertainty, we expect the growth momentum to soften in the second half of the year but keep our annual growth forecast at 7.3% year-on-year this year. Inflation is likely to settle into a higher level after two years of benign rates.

The record build-up in the Reserve Bank of India's foreign reserves has changed the policy calculus, providing policymakers with a substantial buffer against forex volatility, commodity price shocks, and swings in global risk sentiments. Hence, the economy is heading to a period of greater uncertainty



with considerably more policy flexibility than in earlier cycles.

The record forex build-up in RBI reserves has given policymakers a bigger buffer, and room to manoeuvre through commodity price shocks and global risk sentiment

When the dust settles, focus will also be on the bunched-up maturities of foreign

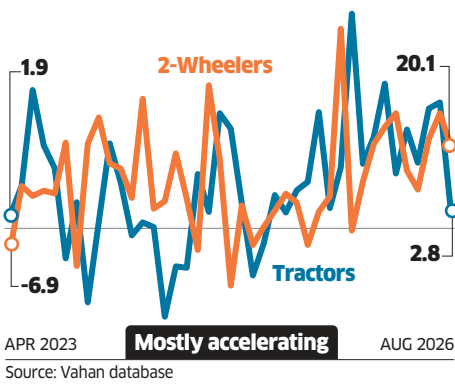
currency non-resident (FCNR) deposits that will fall due in three-five years. A portion of the existing foreign reserve stock could be earmarked against these liabilities, helping to mitigate concerns that deposit maturities or debt repayments could trigger a sharp increase in dollar demand and exert pressure on the forex market down the line.

In the near term, priorities will be to manage liquidity, gradually lower the sizable forwards book and support the domestic currency. Long-end yields continue to be influenced by the hardening global yields.

CONSUMPTION & DEMAND

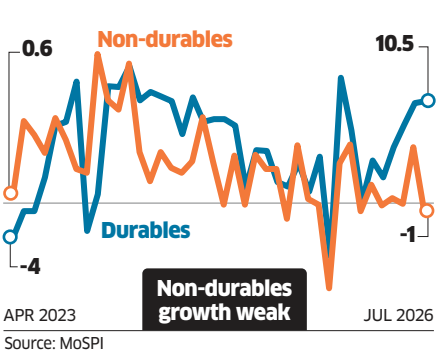
Vehicle Sales Growth (%)

WHY: Buying power in hinterland



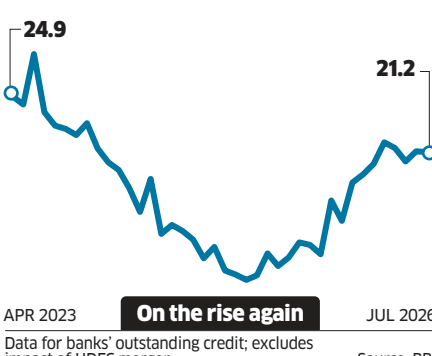
Growth in Industrial Output of Consumer Goods (%)

WHY: Shows what's being produced for buyers



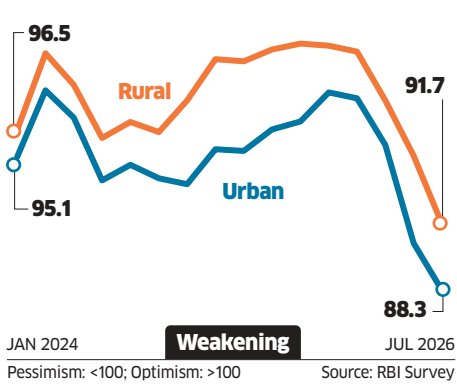
Non-housing Retail Loans Growth (%)

WHY: Credit appetite; but also, how much spending is debt-funded



Consumer Confidence Index

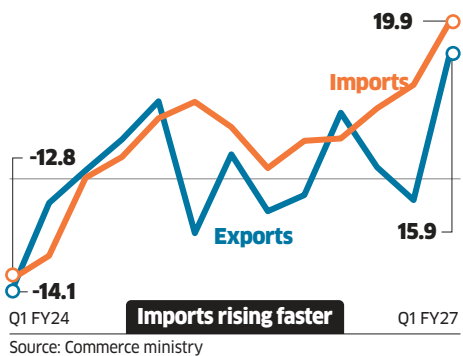
WHY: Households' reading of economy



EXTERNAL SECTOR & COMPETITIVENESS

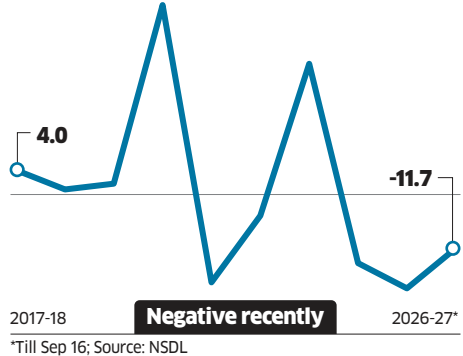
Growth in Goods Trade (%)

WHY: What we buy and sell to the world



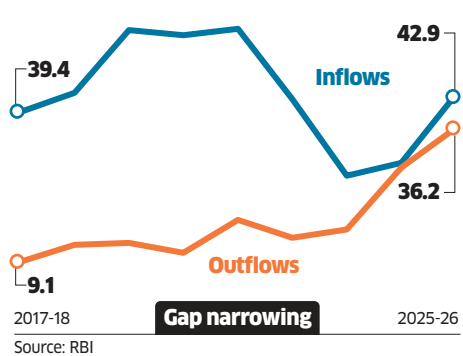
Net Foreign Inflows into Equities (\$ bn)

WHY: Foreign confidence in India's story



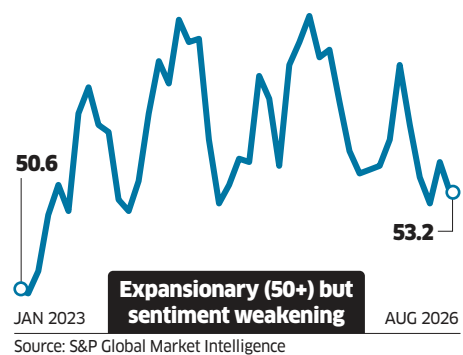
Foreign Direct Investments (\$ bn)

WHY: Long-term capital's vote on India



PMI New Export Orders Sub-index

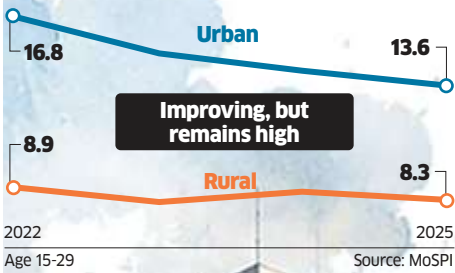
WHY: A lead indicator of external demand



EMPLOYMENT, JOB QUALITY & WAGES

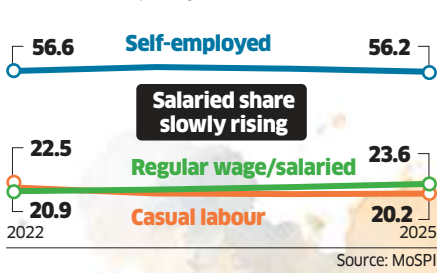
Youth Unemployment Rate (%)

WHY: India's most critical workforce cohort



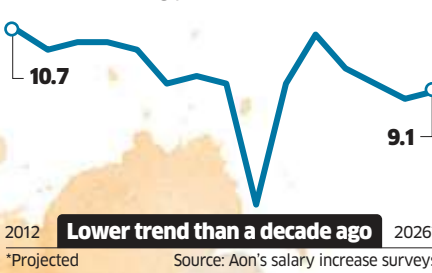
Type of Workers (% Share)

WHY: Tracks quality & formalisation of work



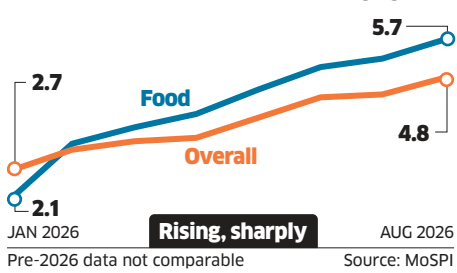
Average Salary Hike in India Inc (%)

WHY: Purchasing power of formal workforce



Retail Inflation (%)

WHY: The number that eats into wage growth

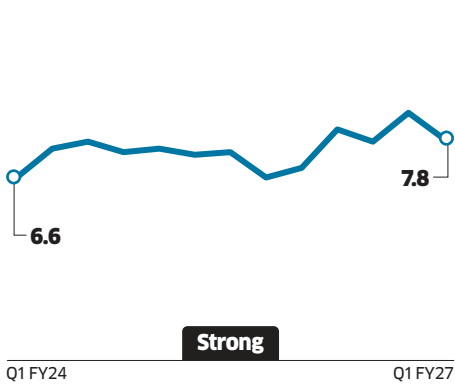


HOW THIS LOOKS LIKE IN GDP ESTIMATES

Source: MoSPI

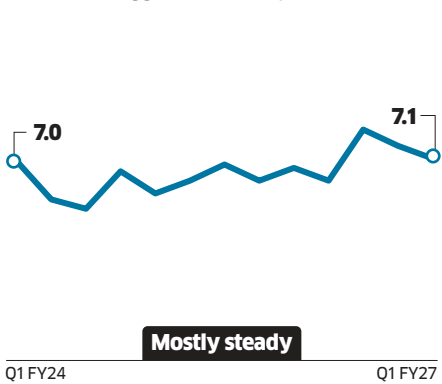
Real GDP Growth (%)

WHY: It all boils down to this number



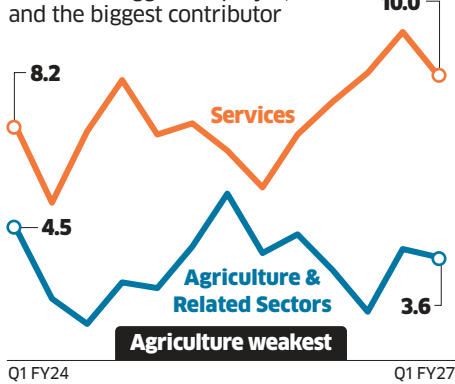
Household Consumption Growth (%)

WHY: The biggest GDP component



Farm and Services Growth (%)

WHY: The biggest employer, and the biggest contributor



Gross Fixed Capital Formation Growth (%)

WHY: How much growth comes from investment



'Need More Structural Growth That Stays High Without Policy Support'



PRANJAL BHANDARI
CHIEF INDIA ECONOMIST/STRATEGIST,
ASEAN ECONOMIST, HSBC

Growth right now is genuinely quite strong because the strength is visible not just in the official GDP numbers, but also in indicators such as credit growth, manufacturing and services PMI, and automobile sales and production. However, much of the current growth is cyclical, supported by pro-growth fiscal and monetary policies. Eventually, what is needed is more structural growth—growth that remains high even without policy support.

India is also at a point where goods exports may do better than they have in the past. One reason is that the currency has depreciated, making exports, especially manufac-

ture exports, more competitive. Since early 2025, the rupee has depreciated 24% against the euro, 20% against the pound, and about 15% in real trade-weighted terms.

Another factor is that India is now signing trade deals with many countries. As tariff rates come down, sometimes significantly, these agreements can provide a strong boost to exports and growth into new markets.

Strong export numbers are already being seen, and if these trade deals are implemented properly, this momentum could pick up over the next year or so.

India's high-tech exports have risen rapidly, but mid-tech exports, mostly labour-intensive goods such as textiles, furniture and footwear, have been sluggish over the last decade.

India is now very good at manufacturing

and exporting mobile phones, but many of the components are still imported. This is India's missing middle: high-tech is doing well, low-tech is fine, but mid-tech is struggling, both in manufacturing and exports.

Fixing this requires ease of doing business, policy certainty, regulatory improvements and better infrastructure. But there is also a specific issue: India's tariff disadvantage is greater for mid-tech, particularly intermediate and components exports. High tariffs reduce the incentive to manufacture these products domestically. Once FTAs are implemented and tariff rates come down, this segment should benefit.

After a very long time, labour-intensive manufacturing and exports could get a better opportunity than they have had in the past. (As told to Anoushka Sawhney)



Exports reveal a missing middle: high-tech goods thriving, labour-intensive mid-tech exports stuck

STORY SO FAR

India's GDP grew 7.8% in Q1FY27, beating expectations

The growth was driven by strong investments, robust factory and services activity, despite concerns over West Asia-related headwinds

This was the third quarterly GDP release under the revised national accounts series with 2022-23 base year

Concerns were raised over unexpectedly high growth number, but govt said the new series captures more data sources and gives better estimates than before

WHAT THE DATA SHOWS

Not all the indicators we chose for this special feature go into the computation of India's GDP. But those that don't may still contribute towards shaping the sentiment that growth is not being felt on the ground

Business-related indicators largely remain strong: credit demand has been accelerating rapidly, capacity utilisation has finally crossed the critical 75% threshold, corporate sales did well in Q1, and a key business expectations index remains above the 100 mark



All this could be contributing to households appearing to be reporting poor consumer sentiment in RBI surveys after the West Asia war began

On the external front, trade momentum is healthy, with export orders expanding (though slower than before); however, volatile foreign flows and faster import growth are constraints

Labour conditions are improving gradually, with better employment quality (salaried workers over self-employed and casual labour). But wage growth may not be to everyone's satisfaction as inflation stays high and a sizeable share of young Indians in the prime employable age remain on the lookout for work

On the consumption side, car and two-wheeler sales growth have been a bright spot, and tractor sales (a proxy for rural demand) have mostly printed healthy numbers. However, industrial output of consumer non-durables, an indicator for rural demand and household buying power, has seen sagging growth. Credit-led spending is strong but has worried some commentators

Lastly, growth is broadening: non-farm sectors remain strong, while agriculture, the biggest employer, is significantly slower. The poor southwest monsoon rainfall isn't good news either



Data, charts, text and reporting by TANAY SUKUMAR, ANOUSHKA SAWHNEY, KIRTIKA SUNEJA; Design: SAMIR KUMAR

SEEKS IRP APPOINTMENT

NCLAT Raises Concerns over NBCC's Supertech Project Delay

PTI

New Delhi: Appellate Insolvency Tribunal NCLAT has raised concerns over construction major NBCC's delay in meeting deadlines set for resumption of work at Supertech's stalled housing projects.

Besides, a three-member bench has also pulled up the authorities over the delay in appointing an interim resolution professional (IRP) for the realty firm, which is currently going through the Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP).

The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) has directed NCLT and the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (IBBI) to suggest names within a week.

"We have been informed that an application for appointment of the IRP has been dealt with by the NCLT, and IBBI is directed to suggest the names. Let the said process be completed within a week from today," the NCLAT said on Friday. The IRP, once named, is also required to head the Apex Court Committee overseeing the stalled Supertech projects and chair the Project-Wise Court Committee, the appellate tribunal noted.

NCLAT, in its 5-page interim order, also noted slippages by state-run construction major NBCC in meeting deadlines set out in its earlier order dated May 6, 2026, for resumption of construction work at Supertech's projects.

"...the order dated June 6, 2026, certain timelines were given to the NBCC for start of the project, viz. Condition-I being satisfied on December 12, 2024, itself and Conditions - II, III, V and VI were to be complied with on or before July 31, 2026," it said.

NBCC was also required to process the award of work as per Condition-IV prior to July 31, 2026, and complete the contract within one month, the NCLAT noted in its order.

EYES HIGHER-VALUE CDMO WORK

Aragen Steps Up Investments in Complex Drug Modalities

Rica Bhattacharyya

Mumbai: Hyderabad-based contract research, development and manufacturing organisation (CRDMO) Aragen Life Sciences is stepping up investments in complex drug modalities such as antibody-drug conjugates (ADCs), peptides, oligonucleotides and high-potent APIs as it seeks to move up the drug development and manufacturing value chain.

Aragen, which works with more than 500 customers, including 16 of the top 20 global pharmaceutical companies, plans to add around 500 kilolitres of small-molecule CDMO capacity, MD and CEO Manni Kantipudi told ET in an exclusive interview. The company is also investing in a biologics drug-product facility, including fill-finish.

Aragen recently filed its draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) with Sebi for an initial public offering. It makes 60,000-70,000 novel molecules a year, with its discovery business expected to provide an important base for expansion.

The move comes as global drugmakers increasingly seek alternatives to China for parts of their global supply chains, prompting Indian CRDMOs to expand.

"Our long-term ambition is to move from being a molecules company

JLR Eyes £1b Loan, but Lenders Discuss Leadership Uncertainty

Bankers wary as group decides to give chairman extension despite Tata Trusts chief's opposition

Sangita Mehta & Kala Vijayraghavan

Mumbai: Tata Motors-backed Jaguar Land Rover has begun talks with global banks to raise about £1 billion through a five-year term loan, but uncertainty surrounding the leadership of the Tata Group could weigh on lenders' decision-making, people familiar with the matter said. JLR began discussing its fundraising plans with eight or nine banks last week, the people said. During the discussions, some lenders suggested that the company delay the fundraising until greater clarity emerged over the continuity of N Chandrasekaran as chairman of Tata Sons, the group holding company.

Uncertain Times

JLR in talks with 8-9 lenders

Parental support key to lenders' assessment

Pricing seen below 200 bps over SONIA

March bond issue postponed amid volatility

**Sterling overnight index average



Chandrasekaran is also chairman of JLR, prompting lenders to seek greater visibility on his continuity before committing to the financing, the people said. Lenders are evaluating the proposed financing in the context of the level of parental support available to JLR, the people said. Their concerns over leadership stem from Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata's opposition to the Tata Sons board decision granting a five-year extension to group chairman Chandrasekaran.

The automaker, however, is confident that it will be able to raise the funds, as developments at its parent group do not have a direct bearing on its operations, people familiar with the matter said.

The proposed term loan is likely to carry a fixed spread over the sterling overnight index average (SONIA), people said. The pricing is expected to be well within 200 basis points over SONIA, they added. JLR has approached banks including HSBC, Citibank, MUFG, DBS and BNP Paribas as part of fundraising discussions, as per the people.

The Tata Group did not comment. Citi declined to comment, while HSBC, MUFG, DBS and BNP Paribas did not respond to ET's emailed queries. Talks are progressing on matter and there has been no impact of any leadership uncertainty on the matter, top executives close to the matter said. "Tata group has never been impacted by such issues in the domestic or global markets," one of the executives said. In March, JLR indefinitely postponed a proposed £500 million senior unsecured bond issue due to volatility in global markets following the US attack on Iran.

At the time, JLR planned to use the net proceeds for general corporate purposes, including the likely repayment of £500 million of the £1 billion drawn from a £2 billion bridge facility put in place in September 2025 during the cyberattack on JLR, and to refinance notes due in January 2026 and November 2026, as per the March 18 statement from S&P Global.

SP Group, Noel Dynamics Changing Post RBI Move

Group supports Tata Sons' listing plan after its proposed 2.5% stake sale gets delayed

Kala Vijayraghavan & Sagar Malviya

Mumbai: The Shapoorji Pallonji (SP) Group is backing a Tata Sons listing after a proposed 2.5% stake sale to monetise part of its holding was delayed, people familiar with the matter said. The SP Group, which owns about 18.37% of Tata Sons, had discussed the sale with Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata, with a tax-efficient structure involving a bank or financial institution being explored. The proposal stalled at Tata Sons and was formally taken to board only after the RBI's directive brought a listing requirement into focus, the people said.

The discussions focused on a limited stake sale rather than an immediate broader monetisation and the proposal envisaged cash proceeds being paid to the SP Group over a defined period, potentially allowing Tata Sons to avoid a listing, the people said. SP Group and Tata Trusts did not comment.

The last discussion on the matter with Tata Sons involved Noel Tata suggesting that separate teams from both sides be created to examine the monetisation proposal, the people said. The monetisation plan discussed earlier was being handled by Farokh Subedar on behalf of Tata Trusts, Ankur Verma representing Tata Sons, and a representative from the SP Group, sources said.

SP Group chairman Shapoor Mistry had publicly backed the listing and said he looked forward to working constructively with Tata Sons on way forward.

The SP Group's backing of a listing now gives the conglomerate another potential route to monetise its stake. A public listing could provide a market-based valuation for its holding and make it easier to attract an investor for part of the

RBI DIRECTIVE Sale proposal was taken to board after RBI's directive to comply with rules applicable to upper-layer NBFCs

stake before an IPO, experts said.

"The SP Group holds just over 18% of Tata Sons and its intent has been to monetise part of this holding in some form," said Ketan Dalal, founder of Katalyst Advisors. "With the IPO now seeming very likely, monetising through an OFS or post IPO, of course, is one possibility."

Post-listing lock-in requirements would need to be considered, he said. "Pricing issues would play an important part, both from the investor point of view and from the SP Group point of view. In any case, it is not a situation of one or the other, but it could be a combination of both routes," Dalal said.

An earlier proposal in July involved a share swap under which SP Group would receive shares in a basket of listed Tata companies in exchange for part of its Tata Sons holding. Tata Sons chairman N Chandrasekaran had announced in early August that he would not seek reappointment when his term ended in February 2027 and did not participate in subsequent discussions.

But he reversed his exit decision and agreed to continue as executive chairman of Tata Sons for another five years after Tata Sons board approved his reappointment on September 17.

'Casting Vote Can't Validate Chandra's Reappointment'

A VIEW POINT Tata Trusts says resolution failed to meet separate voting requirement under AoA

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Tata Trusts rejected the contention that a casting vote could validate the reappointment of N Chandrasekaran as chairman of Tata Sons, saying the resolution failed to meet a separate voting requirement under the holding company's articles of association (AoA).

DISPUTING ARGUMENT

The Trusts, in a statement on Sunday, said two of its nominees sit on the Tata Sons board. The articles require affirmative support from a majority of the directors nominated by Tata Trusts, which owns about 66% of the company, it said. One of the two nominees voted against the resolution at the September 17 board meeting, meaning the required support was not secured, it said.

The Trusts disputed the argument that the vote had resulted in a board deadlock that could be resolved by the chairman's casting vote. "A condition is either met, or it is not," the Trusts said, arguing that the casting vote applies only when there is an equality of votes at the overall board level and cannot override the separate requirement concerning Tata Trusts' nominees. The Trusts said the resolution to reappoint Chandrasekaran, who has led Tata Sons since 2017, was therefore not validly passed and had no legal effect.

The dispute turns on provisions in Tata Sons' articles that give Tata Trusts' nominee directors affirmative voting rights on certain matters. The Trusts said Tata Sons had previously defended those rights before India's Supreme Court during litigation stemming from the removal of former chairman Cyrus Mistry.

Tata Sons had argued in that case that the rights were legitimate protections agreed among shareholders and reflected the Trusts' position as the company's majority shareholder, according to the Trusts' statement. The Supreme Court had accepted Tata Sons' case and overturned a finding that

Show of Support

THE TRUSTS SAID REQUIRED AFFIRMATIVE SUPPORT WAS NOT SECURED

Casting votes apply only to overall board-level ties

Tata Trusts said the resolution had no legal effect

They cannot override special rights for Trusts' nominees

The dispute centers on Tata Sons' shareholder protection provisions



the provisions were oppressive, the Trusts said.

RENEWED SCRUTINY

The latest dispute comes as Tata Sons faces renewed scrutiny over its governance and the possibility of a stock-market listing. The Trusts rejected the argument that listing would necessarily strengthen governance, saying Tata Sons had voluntarily adopted several governance practices associated with public companies, including independent directors, audit and nomination committees, related-party transaction rules and insider-trading provisions.

The statement issued on Sunday marks a fresh escalation in the disagreement over the governance of India's biggest business group, with the Tata Trusts arguing that the articles themselves provide the framework for resolving the board's decision rather than creating a deadlock requiring intervention by the chairman. Trusts said their position was rooted in the role they have played in philanthropy for more than 130 years.

INDIA'S A \$200-M BIZ FOR THE COMPANY, SAYS CEO

Magnum to Reformulate its Products as GLP-1 Drugs, AI Drive Consumption

Sagar Malviya

Mumbai: GLP-1 drugs that are gaining popularity as a diabetes and weight-management tool and artificial intelligence-powered shopping are set to drive food consumption, with India, China and the US already witnessing the change, said Peter Ter Kulve, chief executive of the Magnum Ice Cream Company.

"I believe that GLP-1 and agentic search and shopping will drive food consumption over the coming five, ten years. You see it already happening in certain markets like India, like China, like in the US," ter Kulve said at an investor conference this month.

The company, the world's largest ice-cream maker, is betting on the changing consumption habits and is looking to reformulate its products around emerging consumer preferences around protein, hydration and sugar reduction.

In India, it cut prices by 30%, shifting from vegetable-fat products to dairy ice cream and is installing about 70,000 cabinets, or commercial deep-freeze units, a year. The company, spun off from Unilever last year, is also building five factories in India to lower logistics and manufacturing costs.



India's ice-cream market, estimated to be roughly \$2 billion, remains among the world's fastest growing, helped by a per-capita consumption of just 0.6 litres annually. The category is expanding at about 11%, faster than beauty products.

India, currently a \$200 million business for the company, could eventually become its biggest market, the CEO said. Consumption could eventually reach 5 litres per person, taking India's market beyond that of the US, he said.

The push in India comes after Unilever spun off the business to give it greater autonomy and flexibility in fast-growing markets. The separation was intended to help the division move faster locally and compete more aggressively against regional players.

As part of that strategy, Magnum acquired a 61.9% stake in Kvaliti Wall's, which is listed in India and operates as a subsidiary of the Magnum group that controls more than a fifth of the world's ice-cream segment.

The push is already producing sharp volume growth. Ter Kulve said the company has recorded months in which volumes in India rose 40%, although growth has been helped by a low starting base and strong sales of popsicles.

The Amsterdam-listed maker of Magnum, Cornetto and Kvaliti Wall's believes the Indian business can eventually become profitable on a model similar to its Pakistani operations, which are slightly smaller than its current India business and are already profitable, he said.

"We basically had to decentralise our manufacturing... Lower logistic cost, manufacturing cost will bring margins back in the business," he said during the presentation.

The company is seeking to broaden the occasions in which Indians consume ice cream, including by positioning the product around festivals. "Diwali is not an ice-cream festival yet, but we're turning it into an ice-cream festival," he said during the presentation.

We basically had to decentralise our manufacturing... Lower logistic cost, manufacturing cost will bring margins back in the business

PETER TER KULVE CEO, The Magnum Ice Cream Company

More Flights to Vietnam on the Cards After New Aviation Deal

Arindam Majumder

New Delhi: Indian travellers will have more flight options to Vietnam this holiday season as India and Vietnam have agreed to allow airlines from both countries to launch more flights. The new agreement will more than double the air capacity limit to over 16,000 seats a week from 8,000 now, people aware of the development said.

The expansion comes as airlines on both sides have used up, or are close to exhausting, their existing rights amid growing demand for travel between the two countries.

Flying rights are allocated on a bilateral reciprocal basis by the government to airlines of their country. Airlines cannot operate more flights than they are allotted.

Over last few years, Vietnam has

BIG BOOST



New agreement will more than double the air capacity limit to 16k seats per week

become a popular destination for Indian tourists. According to data analytics firm Cirium, Indian carriers IndiGo and Air India operate 30 flights to Vietnam a week while Vietnamese carriers operate 48 flights. The increase in capacity—effective immediately—will allow Vietnam Airlines and Vietjet to add more flights to Indian metros such as Delhi, Mumbai, Hyderabad, Chennai and Kolkata, people cited above said.

id. Sun PhuQuoc Airlines is also planning to launch flights to Mumbai, they said.

"Vietnam is a hot selling destination from India, driven by an increase in flight connectivity," Nguyen Trung Hieu, India country manager at Vietnam Airlines, told ET. "Vietnam Airlines with its A350 aircraft is the first full service carrier on the route, which will appeal to the premium travellers."

This is the second increase in bilateral seat quota between India and Vietnam since 2024, an unusually quick succession considering New Delhi's cautious approach. The Narendra Modi government has been reluctant to give more access to foreign carriers since it took charge in 2014. This stance, according to the government, is aimed at protecting Indian airlines from being eclipsed by bigger global rivals.

Cos inking partnerships amid supply shortage and four-fold increase in whey protein prices

Ratna Bhushan

New Delhi: A surge in consumer demand for protein in everyday staples has spurred a range of collaborations as food and beverage makers and cafe chains launch new products and close supply deals amid continued global shortage and a four-fold increase in whey protein prices.

Tiger Global-backed tea cafe chain Chaayos has partnered with Slurpp Farm maker Wholsom Foods to launch teas based on the latter's protein brand Mille, while the India unit of Tim Hortons has inked a partnership with Amul to launch protein coffees. Rival Tata Starbucks has teamed up with snacking brand SuperYou to introduce protein cold foam.

"What many years back was a

supplement taken by gym goers is now a daily habit of millions of Indians," said Kannan Sitaram, managing partner at early-stage venture capital firm Fireside Ventures, which has invested in ITC-backed Yoga Bar, nutrition and wellness consumables maker Kapiva and Sweet Karam Coffee.

"The success of GLP-1 medications (for diabetes and weight loss) in India is another factor driving protein consumption as that reduces muscle mass and leads to a sense of weakness," Sitaram added.

Researcher IMARC valued India's total protein market at close to ₹15,300 crore in 2025 and has projected it to reach ₹21,000 crore by 2031 despite prices of whey protein surging amid global supply disruptions.

The spurt in demand is also prompting food companies to invest in new products and manufacturing capacity.

Dairy company Parag Milk Foods entered the protein-snacking category this month, while recently listed dairy maker Milky Mist last fortnight commissioned a ₹40-crore plant in Tamil Nadu to manufacture Skeyr and Greek yoghurt.

"High-protein nutrition is moving from a niche preference to an increasingly mainstream consumption trend," said K Rathnam, chief executive officer of Milky Mist Dairy Food.

Nitin Saluja, cofounder of Chaayos, said the initial response for its

Mille-based protein drink has been "very encouraging."

There is a rise in acquisitions and deals as well.

"There are at least four digital-first protein brand deals currently in the market, as large established players are scouting for tuck-in acquisitions to meet demand for everyday protein staples," an executive at a large private equity firm said on the condition of anonymity.

In February, pharmaceuticals company USV acquired a 79% stake in Wellbeing Nutrition for ₹1,583 crore in an all-cash deal, with Hindustan Unilever exiting its investment in the nutrition products startup.

HUL, on its part, completed a 100% acquisition of plant-based clean-label consumer wellness brand Oziva this year through parent company Zywie. Marico too has acquired plant-based protein wellness label Cosmix.

Specialty food and nutraceutical ingredients startup Arboreal Bio-innovations recently raised ₹230 crore in a round co-led by EAAA Alternatives and Omnivore, while Pune-based protein start-up Provilac raised \$14 million from Panthera Growth Partners.



Building a safer Uttar Pradesh for women



PHOTO: UP GOVT

Uttar Pradesh has strengthened its approach to women's safety through dedicated policing, specialised units, emergency response systems, focused enforcement and stronger mechanisms for investigation and justice. The state has expanded the role of women police personnel, introduced dedicated women beats and strengthened district-level measures to address safety concerns. Integrated services, including the Women Power Line 1090, Women Helpline 181, GRP and Fire Services, further support timely assistance and response. The state has also undertaken focused measures to prevent crimes against women and children, including the deployment of Anti-Romeo Squads and the creation of specialised women-led policing structures. Alongside preventive measures, greater emphasis has been placed on monitoring sexual-offence investigations and ensuring effective prosecution and convictions. These efforts have been accompanied by measurable improvements in several areas. Between October 1, 2025, and June 30, 2026, cases under the POCSO Act declined by 17.01%, kidnapping of women and children by 6.13%, dowry deaths by 43.32% and domestic violence by 13.30%. The state has also recorded a 99.10% disposal rate for cases monitored through the ITSSO portal. From 2017 to 30 June 2026, convictions were secured in 34,734 cases involving crimes against women and minors, 15,402 POCSO cases and 4,714 rape cases, reflecting a broader emphasis on prevention, protection, and access to justice.



INITIATIVES FOR WOMEN'S SAFETY

MISSION SHAKTI CENTRES

Same has been established at every police station in Uttar Pradesh. More than 80,000 police personnel have been trained for its functioning. Several campaigns have been successfully conducted for the safety, dignity and empowerment of women. These include Mission Shakti 5.0, Operation Garuda, Operation Shield, Operation Destroy, Operation Bachpan, Operation Khoj, Operation Dial and Operation Raksha.

WOMEN POLICE PERSONNEL

The state has deployed 19,400 women police personnel across its police stations. This expansion strengthens women-focused policing and creates greater institutional capacity to respond to crimes and concerns involving women.

WOMEN BEATS

A total of 9,172 women beats have been allocated across police stations in Uttar Pradesh. This initiative is a part of the state's efforts to strengthen women-centered policing at the local level. With women police personnel deployed across police stations, the system provides a dedicated policing structure focused on women's safety, accessibility, and the handling of their concerns.

ANTI-ROMEO SQUADS

Anti-Romeo Squads have been constituted in every district. As part of their enforcement efforts, legal action has been taken against 42,226 people. The initiative represents a focused policing mechanism for addressing concerns related to women's safety in public spaces.

WOMEN POWER LINE

Along with GRP, Fire Services and Women Helpline 181, Women Power Line 1090 has been integrated as a part of the state's women-safety framework. The integration brings together multiple support and emergency-response mechanisms.

WOMEN AND CHILD SAFETY ORGANISATION

In every district, a woman Station House Officer has been posted, in addition to the designated women police station. This measure strengthens women's representation within the police force while creating an additional institutional mechanism to address crimes and concerns involving women and children.

WOMEN PAC BATTALIONS

Three women PAC battalions have been constituted, while the process of establishing five additional battalions is under way. The creation of resolute women PAC battalions adds specialised institutional capacity to the state's policing framework. It forms part of the broader measures undertaken to strengthen the safety, security, and protection of women across Uttar Pradesh.

ITSSO MONITORING SYSTEM:

The ITSSO (Investigation Tracking System for Sexual Offences) portal is being effectively monitored. As a result, the disposal rate has reached 99.10%, placing Uttar Pradesh first in the country. With a pendency rate of 0.20%, the state currently ranks second nationally on this parameter. The system strengthens monitoring and disposal of sexual-offence investigations.

Creating secure avenues for women

- ◆ Dedicated support at police stations
- ◆ Greater women's representation in policing
- ◆ Focused beat-level protection
- ◆ Stronger vigilance in public spaces
- ◆ Integrated emergency support services
- ◆ Dedicated mechanisms for women and children
- ◆ Specialised women-led police units
- ◆ Faster monitoring of sexual-offence cases
- ◆ Stronger prosecution and conviction
- ◆ Focused campaigns for safety and empowerment



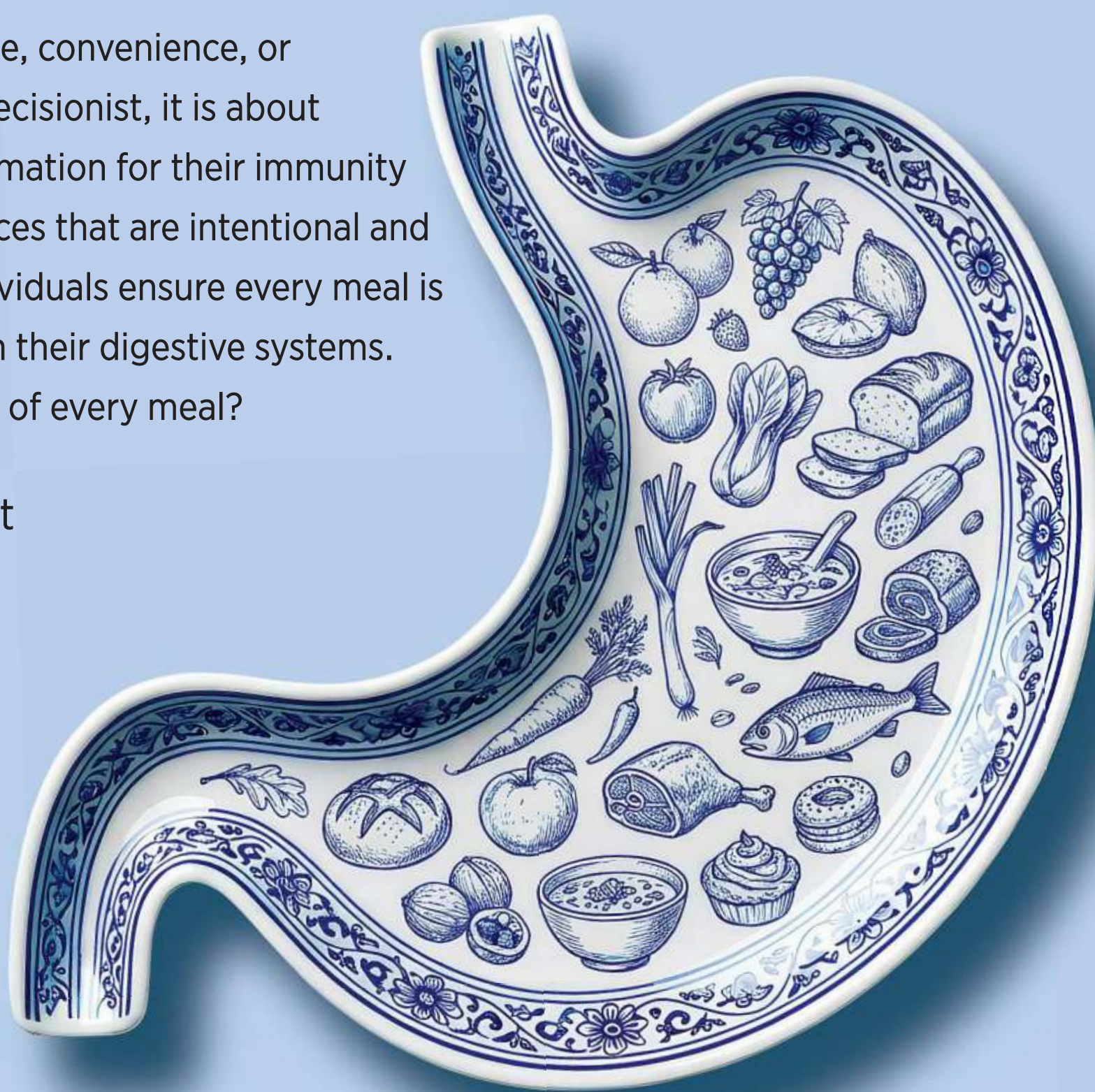
READER ENGAGEMENT INITIATIVE

The Gut Precisionists

a.k.a. Those who follow the art of precision eating

Eating is often about taste, convenience, or habits. But for the gut precisionist, it is about recognising food as information for their immunity and wellbeing. With choices that are intentional and well-informed, these individuals ensure every meal is an opportunity to nourish their digestive systems. Are you making the most of every meal?

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CHANGE Begins Here

BID TO CURB REGULATORY ARBITRAGE, OPERATIONAL MISALIGNMENT

Banks Plan to Align Norms for Project Finance Lending

IN THE WORKS Parameters likely to cover capital outlay, funding amount and gestation period

Dheeraj Tiwari

New Delhi: Banks are working towards a common framework for project finance lending to curb regulatory arbitrage and operational misalignment among consortium lenders, people familiar with the development said.

The common parameters could cover aspects such as capital outlay, amount funded and gestation period, they said.

“There is a need for some common framework so that not all loans are covered under project finance, which can lead to conflicting loan classifications among consortium lenders,” said a bank executive aware of the developments. State-run lenders and private banks are expected to hold discussions to arrive at common parameters. “A common framework will also bring in risk mitigation and avoid issues such as divergent audit observations,” said another bank executive, request-

Lender Alignment

MOVE AIMS to avoid conflicting loan classifications and divergent audit observations

PROJECT FINANCE uses future project revenues as the primary security and source of repayment

RBI GUIDELINES REQUIRE loan disbursements to be proportionate to project completion and equity infusion

LENDERS MUST share a common borrower agreement, though loan terms can differ

RBI ISSUED FINAL GUIDELINES in October 2025, leaving the decision to individual bank boards



ing anonymity. Project finance is funding for a project in which the revenues generated by the project serve as the primary security for the loan and also as a source of repayment.

The Reserve Bank of India has left the decision on the parameters to individual bank boards, allowing them to determine whether a loan can be underwritten as project

finance. “Therefore, it is necessary that the industry be aligned,” the executive said.

Under RBI guidelines, a lender has to ensure that loan disbursement is proportionate to the stages of completion of the project, as well as to progress in equity infusion and other sources of finance agreed as part of financial closure and receipt of remaining applicable

clearances.

“We will be looking to address these issues, so that final guidelines by all bank boards are aligned, and reduce scope for any regulatory arbitrage,” the executive said.

According to RBI, project finance may take the form of financing the construction of a new capital installation (greenfield) or financing an improvement or enhancement in an existing installation (brownfield).

In the final guidelines effective October 2025, RBI rationalised the standard asset provisioning requirement to 1% for projects under construction.

The requirement for under-construction commercial real estate, or CRE, exposures was pegged at 1.25%.

The guidelines mandate that all lenders should have a common agreement with the debtor, but allow different loan terms for each lender, provided these are agreed upon by the debtor and all lenders for the project.

India's Exports to Core BRICS Nations Jump 34% in April-August

New Delhi: India's exports to China, South Africa, Brazil and Russia grew 34% to \$19.9 billion in April-August 2026-27, led by a 39 per cent jump in shipments to China, highlighting the growing importance of the BRICS bloc for India's export growth. “As India deepens its engagement with the BRICS bloc, strongest momentum is coming from the BRICS members, especially Core BRICS founding partners—China, South Africa, Brazil, and Russia,” an official said.

BRICS, originally comprising Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa, expanded in 2024 to include Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, the United Arab Emirates and Saudi Arabia, with Indonesia joining in

2025. Belarus, Bolivia, Kazakhstan, Cuba, Malaysia, Nigeria, Thailand, Uganda, Uzbekistan and Vietnam became BRICS partner countries last year. As per commerce ministry data, exports to four core BRICS economies grew by 34%, rising from USD 14.9 billion in April-August 2025-26 to \$19.9 billion in April-August 2026-27. The share of four countries in India's total exports increased from 9.2% during first five months of this fiscal from 8.1% in same period of 2025-26. **PTI**



PUSH TO CREATE LARGE CONSULTING ENTITIES TO COMPETE WITH BIG 4

ICAI Readies CA Act Changes to Build Bigger Accounting Firms

Proposals include measured deregulation of non-assurance services for CAs

Twesh Mishra

New Delhi: The Institute of Chartered Accountants of India is set to approach the government with proposed changes to the Chartered Accountants Act that could pave the way for larger Indian accounting and consulting firms, people familiar with the development said.

The move comes as the Centre pushes to create large local consulting entities capable of competing with the global ‘Big-4 firms’—EY, Deloitte, KPMG and PwC.

The Prime Minister's Office has held multiple deliberations on regulatory changes needed to help domestic firms scale up and capture a share of the \$240-billion global auditing and consultancy market.

“We can say ICAI proposal will be ready in the next two months,” an ICAI official told ET.

A decision on the suggestions will be taken by the ministry of corporate affairs and later by Parliament if the Act is amended.

ICAI's proposals include amendments to the Chartered Accountants Act for measured deregulation of non-assurance services, providing greater flexibility and a level playing field for CAs in consultancy and advisory work.

In 2017, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had called for at least four Indian entities to be among the top eight globally.

ICAI also plans to revise its 2021 networking guidelines and 2006 guidelines governing practice in corporate form.

The expanded framework will allow networks to onboard multidisciplinary entities, including company secretaries, cost accountants, advocates, engineers, architects and actuaries, alongside ICAI-registered multidisciplinary partnerships and other professional entities.

“The objective is to facilitate participation by professionals regulated under respective laws. This aims widening expertise and service capabilities and creating firms of greater institutional scale,” the official said.



Sports World Play

VITALS

CHess OLYMPIAD

Indian Men Cruise Past the Dutch, Poland Shock Women



Samarkand: Led by R Praggnanandhaa on the top board and world champion D Gukesh on the fourth, the Indian men scored an emphatic 3-1 victory over Holland but the Indian eves were shocked by Poland in the fifth round of the 46th chess Olympiad here. On the second board, Arjun Erigaisi played out a draw with Jordan Van Foreest, while Nihal Sarin did not face many hurdles and drew with Loek Van Wely on the third. For the top ranked Indian women, it was a heartbreak as R Vaishali lost to Aleksandra Mal'tsevs'kaya on the second board, while the other three games ended in draws. This resulted in a loss with minimal margin of 1.5-2.5 for the Indian eves and it remains to be seen how they bounce back with six rounds still remaining in the biggest chess event of the world. **PTI**

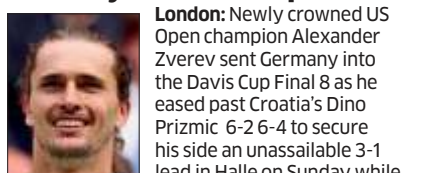
Atletiko KO 10-man Real as Man City Win Eight-goal Thriller



Madrid: Atletico Madrid won the first capital derby of the season in the Spanish league with a 2-1 win against 10-man Real Madrid, while Manchester City prevailed in an eight-goal thriller against Sunderland to move clear at the top of the Premier League.

Alejandro Grimaldo and Jonathan David scored second-half goals for Atletico, which moved to second place behind Barcelona. Man City beat Sunderland 5-3 to open a three-point lead over defending champion Arsenal in England. Atletico takes advantage of 10-man Madrid Atletico scored twice in the second half to beat its city rival, which played a man down nearly the entire second half at the Metropolitan stadium. Dean Huijsen was sent off in the 52nd for a foul that prompted the penalty kick converted by Grimaldo. **AP**

World No.1 Zverev Leads Germany into Davis Cup Final 8



London: Newly crowned US Open champion Alexander Zverev sent Germany into the Davis Cup Final 8 as he eased past Croatia's Dino Prizmic 6-2 6-4 to secure his side an unassailable 3-1 lead in Halle on Sunday while Spain also progressed. Britain ensured they will be one of the eight nations to compete for the trophy over six days in Bologna in November as they comfortably beat Ecuador 4-0. Austria, Canada, South Korea and the Czech Republic all moved through as they won their qualifiers on Saturday. Italy qualified automatically as reigning champions. **Reuters**

SILVER BULLET

ASIAN GAMES 2026

Elavenil Valarivan fires India to twin medals on day one

Ajai Masand

Nagoya: India's shooting campaign at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games began on a high note, with experienced rifle shooter Elavenil Valarivan playing a starring role in the country's double-silver haul in the women's 10m air rifle competition on Sunday.

Elavenil, one of India's most accomplished rifle shooters, helped the country secure silver in the team event before adding an individual silver later in the day. The latter, however, came with a hint of disappointment as the Tamil Nadu-born shooter appeared firmly on course for gold for most of the final, only to see her challenge fade in the closing stages as Japan's Hinata Taichi held her nerve to emerge champion.

The 2025 World Championship bronze medallist finished with 252.4 points, just 0.6 behind Taichi, who clinched gold with an Asian Games

SHOT BY SHOT

● With **252.4 pts**, Valarivan finished **0.6 pts** behind Japan's Taichi's **253**—an Asian record

● In the final shot, Valarivan managed **10.1**. But Taichi held her nerve with **10.2 for the gold**

● After the **21st shot**, the Indian shooter was ahead by **0.2 pts**

record 253.0. South Korea's Ban Hyojin, the reigning world champion and Paris Olympics gold medallist, took bronze with 230.4.

For Elavenil, the silver was her first individual medal at the Asian Games, having competed at the 2018 Jakarta and 2022 Hangzhou editions without making the podium. She had looked in complete command for much of the final and seemed to have the gold within her sights. After the 17th shot, she held a 1.4-point advantage over Ban, with Taichi lying third. Even after the 21st shot, Elavenil was



(From L) Vidarsa Vinod, Sonam Maskar and Elavenil Valarivan after their win **AP**

still ahead of the Japanese shooter by 0.2.

But as the pressure intensified, the margins narrowed.

Elavenil entered the final two shots just 0.3 points behind Taichi. She responded with a 10.4, but the Japanese shooter produced a 10.6 to stretch her advantage to 0.5.

With one shot remaining, Elavenil needed something special to turn the contest around. She managed 10.1. Taichi, however, held her nerve and answered with a 10.2 to secure gold and rewrite the Asian Games record.

Elavenil admitted that being in a commanding position may have allowed her concentration to dip slightly. “I think I knew that somewhere I was in the top three and although I was coming back to focusing on my process and my technique, I did get a bit relaxed. I really need to work on my finals some more. I think that's all. I felt I gave my absolute best and I'm glad it turned out that way,” she said.

The result capped a strong run for the Tamil Nadu-born shooter, who has been among India's most consistent rifle exponents over the past year. She won silver at the 2025 Asian Championships in Shymkent and repeated that feat at the 2026 edition in New Delhi.

Before stepping onto the individual final range, however, Elavenil had al-

Homegrown Talent, MCC Footprint to Make India a Global Production Hub

WORLD STAGE AI, policy support, and growing base expanding ambitions for content creators

Javed Farooqui

Mumbai: India's growing capabilities in artificial intelligence, creative talent pool and expanding media capability centres could position the country as a global content production hub, according to industry experts.

The opportunity extends beyond visual effects where India has traditionally been strong as well as outsourcing, with AI-enabled production potentially allowing the country to create content at scale for international studios, streaming platforms and brands.

Government initiatives such as WAVES, WAVES Bazaar and Create in India Challenges aim to connect Indian creators with global markets, investors and producers. Talent from tier-II and tier-III cities, alongside investments in animation, visual effects, gaming and comics (AVGC), is strengthening the foundation for a scalable content ecosystem.

“India has a huge opportunity to become the world's content creation hub, given its young population, AI talent, creative capabilities, access to technology and cost arbitrage. While VFX is one opportunity, the potential extends to global capability centres producing content at scale for major studios and brands,” said Chandrashekar Mantha, partner and media and entertainment sector leader at Deloitte India.

“India's diversity is a critical strength, with talent increasingly emerging from tier-II and tier-III cities. Governments are also focusing on AVGC education and talent development. A lot of foundational work has started, and if it fructifies in the right way, India has significant potential to become the content hub for the world,” he said.

The government is also working on an integrated National AVGC-XR Mission/Policy to establish objectives, measurable outcomes, institutional mechanisms and a funding framework for the sector, according to a recent report of the

Govt Rolls Out ₹23,731-Cr GOBARdhan Scheme

New Delhi: The government has operationalised its ₹23,731-crore GOBARdhan scheme for compressed biogas (CBG), offering producers assured offtake of up to 100% of their output, a government-backed administered price for at least 10 years and capital assistance, in a bid to make waste-to-energy projects more commercially viable and attract private investment.

The Plot Twist



Parliamentary Committee on Communications and Information Technology.

The proposed policy aims to strengthen the creative economy through industry-aligned skilling, incentives for original content and intellectual property creation, startup incubation and greater participation in global markets and co-production platforms, the report said.

Minister of state for information and broadcasting L Murugan said in the Lok Sabha in April that the government was promoting the media and entertainment sector as part of its vision to strengthen the orange economy and position India as a global content creation hub.

Under the union budget 2026-27 proposals, the government announced AVGC content creator labs in 15,000 secondary schools and 500 colleges, with an allocation of Rs 250 crore. The central and Maharashtra governments, together with industry bodies CII and Ficci, have established the Indian Institute of Creative Technologies (IICT), which opened its campus in Mumbai last year.

The Petroleum and Natural Gas Ministry, in operational guidelines dated September 15, has laid down detailed mechanisms for the scheme, which will run from 2026-27 to 2035-36 and seeks to establish a more predictable market for CBG producers. GOBARdhan is government's programme to turn organic waste into useful products like biogas, CBG & organic manure. **PTI**

'HAD A CHILDHOOD DREAM TO FIGHT'

Suchika Tariyal, a victim of eve-teasing, assures India of 1st-ever MMA medal



Nagoya: At 12, an incident of eve-teasing left Suchika Tariyal with a simple thought: “I wanted to learn how to fight”.

Twenty-four years later, that decision has taken the 36-year-old from judo mats in Haryana to the Asian Games podium, where she assured India of its first medal at the Aichi-Nagoya Games by beating Mongolia's Altanchimeg Baigalma 2-0 to enter the semifinals of the women's Traditional Mixed Martial Arts (MMA) 60kg event on Sunday.

The semifinals at the Nagoya City Inae Sports Centre on Monday will give Tariyal a chance to turn her assured bronze into a gold.

A place in the last four guarantees a medal, with both losing semifinalists receiving bronze.

“It's great to have assured one medal for the country. It's time for me to give that fight for a gold medal tomorrow,” Tariyal said after her victory. **PTI**

Vinod, she combined to give India its first medal from the shooting ranges.

The Indian trio aggregated 1898.0 points to finish second behind a dominant Chinese team, which shattered the qualification world record with 1904.2. China bettered its own previous mark of 1902.0, set at the Asian Championships in Shymkent last August. **PTI**

‘Focus on Design Ecosystem’

ET INTERVIEW

» From Page 1

If you are creating something, then you might as well see that it is safe. What’s happening with AI is that the development pace is very rapid, extremely rapid. Whatever we thought a quarter ago is irrelevant today. That rapid pace brings risks with it, and the industry is cognisant of those risks. Some of the incidents that have happened recently are alarming. What are the liabilities of agents? Who is liable if an agent does something very serious, such as breaking down a grid or pushing a student towards suicide? Or allowing or forcing a car to suddenly brake in the middle of traffic? Those questions have to be answered. The industry has to answer them and take the lead because, unlike physical technology, where it is easier to find what to regulate and what to check, that kind of measurement in AI is very difficult. The designers and builders of those models know where the issues are. They have to be on board in the regulatory journey.

There’s already \$11-12b of interest in ISM 2.0. While govt has committed around \$23-24b, other countries are committing much larger sums. What does India offer that’s attracting firms?

Your point is right. Many of these countries are pouring in hundreds of billions of dollars. In our country, there are competing demands on capital. We cannot afford to put that much investment into the semiconductor industry because there are competing investments in agriculture, education, healthcare and

everywhere else. What we offer as a differentiating factor is design capability. From day one, when we designed this programme, we said we would build upon this strength. That’s why we gave the latest semiconductor design tools, EDA (electronic design automation) tools, to institutions and universities. (In the second phase), it will be important to make sure the design ecosystem comes up because the next generation should see a Qualcomm or an Intel coming out of India. In pillar two, if we get three large equipment manufacturers and three large materials manufacturers setting up in India, it would be a good success. For fabs, we will focus on niche products. These will give us the capability to bring value to the global semiconductor industry. In advanced packaging, much of the value and increase in capacity and compute capability will come through advanced packaging as Moore’s law gets phased out. There are companies that would like to set up equipment design and manufacturing. They are already talking to precision manufacturing companies. Precision manufacturing is a horizontal that serves multiple industries – aeronautical, space, defence, electronics and semiconductor. The



Ashwini Vaishnaw, Union minister for electronics and IT, railways, I&B

HUMANITY COMES FIRST
Countries need to come together and reach a consensus that humanity comes first and AI has to be safe

demand from semiconductors will help develop that horizontal, which will also benefit defence, space and aeronautical manufacturing.

What is our progress on the AI law?
We have had multiple discussions with AI developers, the development community, academia and global Big Tech companies on this topic. A consensus is building that innovation is very important, but here the risks outweigh the challenges that we see. They outweigh the positive outcomes which might come from AI. Regulation has to be framed looking at that. But again, it has to be a technological approach. The companies developing the models have to

take a much bigger share of the responsibility. Just passing a law will not help. Safeguards and guardrails have to be built by companies within the models themselves.

Can India take a lead in building greater cooperation between governments on AI?

India has, throughout the AI summit and after that, taken this conversation forward with many countries. I think something similar to the nuclear kind of thing will have to happen in the AI world, where countries come together and reach a consensus that humanity comes first, it has to be safe, and AI has to bring value to the world rather than becoming a threat.

On social media harms and child safety, how can platforms have greater responsibility?

Child safety is paramount for us. It’s the next generation that has to have the benefit of technology, but should not get the harms coming from addictiveness, from the way algorithms target young citizens and make them addicted or hooked onto mobile phones or social media platforms, and from the kind of content young people see. That is something every society in the world is grappling with. Many models have already emerged, and a consensus is building around that. The time has come in our country also to have that framework where child safety, women’s safety and online safety of our citizens are balanced with the benefits that come from technology.

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Value Commerce Startup CityMall Eyes ₹500cr from Jungle & Others

Upcoming round likely to value non-metro-focused startup at around ₹4k crore, say sources

Pranav Mukul

New Delhi: CityMall, a value e-commerce startup focusing on non-metro customers, is in talks to raise ₹400-500 crore in fresh funding led by existing investor Jungle Ventures at an expected valuation of around ₹4,000 crore, people aware of the matter told ET.

The round is expected to see participation from new investors as well as existing shareholders. “The company has started preparing for an initial public offering over the next six to eight quarters,” one of the people said.

CityMall had last raised ₹350 crore in equity at a valuation of ₹3,000 crore in September 2025 from Accel, WaterBridge Ventures, Ele-



vation Capital, General Catalyst and others. In 2022, it had raised \$75 million at the same valuation in a round led by Norwest Venture Partners. Email queries sent to CityMall cofounder Angad Kikla and Jungle Ventures were unanswered at the time of publishing.

The Gurgaon-based startup clocked around ₹1,000 crore in revenue in fiscal 2026, nearly double the ₹534 crore it reported in FY25, according to the person quoted above.

The growth is driven by its push into e-commerce in smaller towns and cities. It is currently present in

Adding to Cart

Round is expected to see participation from new and earlier investors

\$75 million raised by company in 2022 at ₹3000 crore valuation

₹350 cr raised in equity funding in September 2025

Firm doubled its revenue to around **₹1,000 cr** in FY26

18 markets across Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Delhi-NCR and Haryana.

It comes at a time when leading 10-minute delivery players, including larger e-commerce platforms’ quick-commerce arms Flipkart Minutes and Amazon Now, are also expanding their presence in tier-II and beyond markets.

“CityMall serves a very different customer from quick commerce,” a person privy to the company’s business strategy said. “The company’s average basket size is around ₹850, and it is largely a planned purchase rather than an impulse one. The quick-commerce customer, by comparison, is more willing to pay a premium for immediacy and convenience.” The person added that around 70% of CityMall’s customers also shop on Meesho.

Founded in 2019 by Kikla, Naisheel Verdhan and Rahul Gill, CityMall sells groceries as well as products across home, kitchen, small electronics and general merchandise. It follows a next-day delivery model and offers these mass-market categories at affordable prices through its own private labels as well as a selection of regional brands.

Chipmakers Moving to ‘Security by Design’ as AI Moves to Cloud

Hardware-level security is becoming foundational in chip design

Alenjith K Johny

Bengaluru: As AI-enabled hardware spreads across cars, cameras and other connected devices, semiconductor companies are moving cybersecurity deeper into chip design and testing to guard against growing cyberattack risks.

Silicon Labs is upgrading security in its products, while semiconductor services firm Tessolve helps customers validate and test security features in chips. Zoho-backed Indian chipmaker Netrasemi is incorporating security features into chips that will be used in surveillance cameras. The shift is being driven by the grow-

ing volume of data moving between connected devices and cloud systems, said Tarun Mehta, staff product marketing manager, India, at Silicon Labs. “As we are moving through

TIGHTER NORMS

The push for stronger security comes as the government also tightens requirements for connected devices

AI, we are putting more and more data on the cloud. A lot of data is travelling from one point to another, and it is vulnerable to threats and cyberattacks,” Mehta said. The challenge is relevant in automotive sector, where number of electronic control units, sensors and computing devices in vehicles is increasing.



‘Open PLI Scheme to Smaller Firms to Drive Green Transition’

Local tech, not just assembly, key to green economy surge: Jhunjhunwala

Puran Choudhary

Bengaluru: IIT-Madras professor Ashok Jhunjhunwala has called for a review of India’s production-linked incentive (PLI) scheme, arguing that it favours established players over startups developing new technologies.

PLI should be opened to smaller companies, with incentives tied to meaningful domestic value addition rather than the ability to make large up-front investments, Jhunjhunwala said in a chat with

“Smaller companies should also be able to qualify. And the incentive should demand serious value addition, not just a small amount of domestic manufacturing”

ASHOK JHUNJHUNWALA
Professor, IIT-Madras

ET. The green economy expert serves as chairman of the non-profit Immersive Technology and Entrepreneurship Labs (ITEL). Jhunjhunwala’s assessment comes amid growing criticism of the government’s PLI framework from EV startups, with companies such as Ather, Euler Motors and Riv-

er arguing that the scheme favours established automakers.

“Smaller companies should also be able to qualify. And the incentive should demand serious value addition, not just a small amount of domestic manufacturing,” Jhunjhunwala said, adding that the advanced chemistry cell (ACC) battery PLI also needs an overhaul.

Jhunjhunwala believes green transition can become an important industrial and employment opportunity for India. The gains would come not merely from assembling green products in India but also from developing the underlying designs, materials and components domestically.

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GRIT & GREATNESS Inside the minds of the ETSA winners rewriting India’s startup playbook

Emergent Expands from Apps to Small Biz AI Automation

ET’s Comeback Kid looking to become an operating system for small businesses



I don’t see a reason why, in two years’ time, most businesses won’t run autonomously, with agents doing most of the work

MUKUND JHA
Cofounder & CEO, Emergent

IDFC FIRST Bank
presents

THE ECONOMIC TIMES
STARTUP AWARDS 2026

Nikhil Patwardhan & Pranav Mukul

Bengaluru | New Delhi: Artificial intelligence startup Emergent is expanding beyond software building to automating day-to-day functions for small businesses and expects the share of AI agent business in its revenue to increase significantly in 15-20 months, cofounder and chief executive Mukund Jha said. “We are slowly expanding into becoming an operating system for small businesses,” Jha told ET in an interview.

The company is testing agents that can remain active in the background, monitor business metrics and help with tasks such as cash-flow analysis, scheduling and social media management. More than half of its team is working on its core agent technology, he said.

Emergent currently allows users to build web and mobile applications using natural-language prompts, but its broader plan is to help businesses automate parts of their operations after those applications are built.

Jha won the Comeback Kid category at The Economic Times Startup Awards 2026. His first act Dunzo — once among India’s best-funded hyperlocal delivery startups — un-

ravelled following an expensive quick commerce expansion and a funding crunch.

Previous winners in the category include Capillary Technologies’ Anesh Reddy and Anant Choubey, and Rentomojo’s Geetansh Bamania, who steered their companies through precarious periods and bounced back. Capillary Technologies went public in November 2025, while Rentomojo listed on the bourses on September 17.

Emergent competes with global AI software-building companies such as Replit, Lovable and Cursor. In July, it raised \$130 million at a \$1.5-billion valuation, five times the valuation at its previous funding round six months earlier. The round — which saw backing from private equity firm Creagis, Ranjan Pai’s family office vehicles MNI Ventures and Claypond Capital, venture capital firm Sentinel Global, Silicon Valley tech billionaire Vinod Khosla’s venture fund Khosla Ventures, SoftBank, Lightspeed and Y Combinator — took its total funding to about \$230 million.

AGENTIC AI PUSH

“Moving from software to agents is a natural extension for us,” Jha said. “I think as the technology progresses and the models get better, the ambition of people building with them, increasingly, is to build more complex applications across the board,” he said. “So, a lot of our focus now is on expanding the platform to help businesses that are coming online become AI-native... (and figuring out) how do we help them automate large parts of their business and truly build a platform that allows businesses to become autonomous?”

Emergent’s push for agentic AI comes at a time when platforms such as Instinct and Meta’s Muse are gaining rapid traction in the consumer AI agents space. US-based Instinct, which last raised \$350 million at a \$2.5 billion valuation in August led by Index Ventures and Benchmark, is in talks to raise a new round at a \$10 billion valuation. “I don’t see a reason why, in two years’ time, most businesses won’t run autonomously, with agents doing most of the work,” Jha said.

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Tech Trotter Meanwhile in tech...

Anthropic, OpenAI, SpaceXAI and Google Face ‘AI Slowdown’ Lawsuit

Washington: A new lawsuit claims Anthropic, OpenAI, SpaceXAI and Google made an illegal deal to slow the pace of their respective AI development. The lawsuit, which was filed on Friday in the US District Court for the Northern District of California, argues that the leading AI companies violated anti-

trust laws when they agreed to coordinate slowdown efforts, and that doing so would reduce the value consumers get for paid AI subscriptions. The coordination largely took place on September 12, the lawsuit argues, when Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei published an essay urging for industrywide cooperation on decelerating advancements. —AP

Valley Fears End of the World While India Fears End of Jobs

Indian engineers face immediate reality of vanishing entry-level roles

Tanya Pandey

New Delhi: As Silicon Valley grows increasingly worried about whether artificial intelligence could eventually become dangerous enough to threaten humanity, Indian AI startup founders told ET that the major concern among engineers here is far more immediate. It is whether AI will take away their jobs and make their skills less valuable.

“General engineers I know in SF are mostly cautious about how AI is going to affect their own jobs, while having some sense of implementing guard-rails for future misuse,” said Harshit Yadav, founder,

Zingroll, an AI filmmaking platform. “In India, the only panic I see among engineers is entry-level



groll.” Yadav said he sees a clear divide in San Francisco between engineers who deeply care about AI’s impact and those who are less concerned as long as what they build reaches production at scale. “In India, career progress and prospects seem more crucial for candidates than any risks of working on a dangerous technology,” he said. The contrast comes as concerns over AI risks have intensified in the US. Anthropic researcher Jacob Coxon recently quit his job, warning that AI companies were “racing straight to self-improving superintelligence and gambling with our lives”.

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